SPREAD LOVE & ACCEPTANCE · BOOK 1

Know Yourself Kindly

Where your lens came from, who you are now, and who you are becoming



by Christian

Christian's Lab
spreadloveandacceptance.com

Spread Love & Acceptance, Book 1: *Know Yourself Kindly*.
By Christian. Published by Christian's Lab, spreadloveandacceptance.com.

Text and pictures © 2026 Christian. First print edition, October 2026. Printed on demand.

ISBN: [to be added] (paperback)

Free online, always. Every chapter of the series is free to read at spreadloveandacceptance.com/book, in a short and a full version, with no account and no paid version. The print books are optional. You may copy pages of this book for personal use and for non-commercial teaching, with credit to "Spread Love & Acceptance, spreadloveandacceptance.com".

Not therapy. This book is general education about people and relationships. It is not a diagnosis, treatment or a replacement for help from a doctor, counsellor or other trained professional, and it can't know your situation.

If you are not safe. If you feel afraid of someone you live with, or someone controls your money, phone or movements, that is not a problem to fix with a worksheet. spreadloveandacceptance.com/safety lists free, private help. If you are in danger now, call your local emergency number.

The examples are made up. The people in this book's examples are made up; any likeness to real people is coincidence. None of them is a testimonial.

The research the chapters mention is listed in short at the back. The full list, with what each study found and links, is at spreadloveandacceptance.com/research.

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Contents

About this book, and how to use it 4

Workpapers, tools and three friends 5

If you need help now 6

1 Know yourself: then, where your lens came from 9

2 Know yourself: now, your wiring, your weather and your words 25

3 Know yourself: next, shaping who you are becoming 45

4 How feelings work: signals, the body, and naming what you feel 61

5 Self-worth, shame and self-compassion 79

6 Personality, temperament and change across life 93

7 Minds that work differently 111

Questions people ask 137

Workpapers and tools in this book 139

Words used in this book 141

Research notes 144

Free on the website 150

The series 152

Your notes 153

About this book, and how to use it

This book starts with you. It looks at where your way of seeing things came from, how you are wired today, how feelings work, why your worth was never a score, how personality works and how minds can work differently.

It is for anyone who wants to understand themselves a little better, at their own pace. You don't need a partner, a problem or a diagnosis to read it, and nothing in it is a test.

Read the chapters in any order. Each is a short version of a chapter that is free to read online, where the full version has more research, more examples and more to try. The code at the end of each chapter opens it on your phone.

HERE	ABOUT	FREE ONLINE AT SPREADLOVEANDACCEPTANCE.COM/BOOK
Chapter 1	Where your lens came from	…/book/self-1-then
Chapter 2	Your wiring, weather and words	…/book/self-2-now
Chapter 3	Who you are becoming	…/book/self-3-next
Chapter 4	How feelings work	…/book/understanding-1-feelings
Chapter 5	Self-worth, shame and self-compassion	…/book/understanding-7-worth
Chapter 6	Personality, temperament and change	…/book/understanding-14-personality
Chapter 7	Minds that work differently	…/book/understanding-9-minds

There are four books in the series, and each stands on its own. The others are Book 2, *Heal and Steady*, about the heavy days; Book 3, *Understanding Each Other*, about understanding the people around you; Book 4, *Share the Load*, about sharing the work of a shared life. When a chapter mentions another book, it gives the book, the chapter and the page in that book, as in "Book 2, Chapter 1 (page 9)". The workbook, The Workpapers, has every form from the series on big pages.

FIVE BIG IDEAS

Five ideas run under the whole series.

- **See the whole load.** Count the unseen work too, the noticing, remembering and planning, yours and other people's.
- **Fix the setup, not the person.** When something keeps going wrong, change the arrangement around it before you blame anyone.
- **Read your state first.** How full your day already is changes how every word sounds, so check yourself before you react.
- **Tune how you send and receive.** People differ in pace, tone and wiring, and a mismatch is something to translate, never a fault.
- **Notice the quiet incentives.** Jobs nobody owns drift to whoever notices first, and a named owner and a real thank-you stop the drift.

Some chapters mention the six-week program, a free plan on the website with one small step a week (spreadloveandacceptance.com/prog-01). The workbook has a planner for it. The people in this book's examples are made up; any likeness to real people is coincidence.

Workpapers, tools and three friends

WORKPAPER WP-11 **A workpaper** is a page you fill in, on your own or together, such as “Workpaper WP-11: The Calm-Down Kit”. Every workpaper is free to print or to fill in on the website, and the book gives a code to scan for each one. *The Workpapers: The Bound Edition* has them all in one place, on big pages.

TOOL **A tool** is a helper you use on the website, such as “Tool: How you connect: the 2-minute style quiz”. You use it and it gives you something back.

Workpapers and tools are kept in separate lists. Both are free and need no account, and what you type stays on your own device.

THREE FRIENDS WHO GIVE HINTS



Professor Puddles, the cheerful raindrop professor, gives most of the hints.



Tidbit, the quick, curious pup, bounds in with a playful tip.



Sugarfoot, the steady, gentle pup, turns up with a calm, slow tip.

They keep to the lighter pages. Where a chapter talks about crisis, deep grief or being hurt, the pages stay quiet and plain.

If you need help now

If you might act on thoughts of ending your life, or someone is in danger right now, call your local emergency number: 999 in the UK, 112 or 999 in Ireland, 911 in the US and Canada, 000 in Australia, 111 in New Zealand.

If you are struggling, or worried about someone else, you can talk to a trained person now. These lines are free, private and open day and night. You don't have to be sure it is a crisis to call or text.

WHERE YOU ARE	CALL OR TEXT
United States	Call or text **988** (the 988 Suicide & Crisis Lifeline), or chat at 988lifeline.org. You can also text HOME to **741741** (Crisis Text Line).
United Kingdom	Call Samaritans free on **116 123**. Or text SHOUT to **85258** (Shout, a free text line).
Ireland	Call Samaritans free on **116 123**.
Canada	Call or text **9-8-8** (the Suicide Crisis Helpline), in English or French.
Australia	Call Lifeline on **13 11 14**, or text 0477 13 11 14.
New Zealand	Call or text **1737** (Need to talk?).
Anywhere else	**findahelpline.com** lists free helplines in many countries, by phone, text and chat.

For children and young people

UK	Childline, **0800 1111** (free, for anyone under 19)
Ireland	Childline, **1800 66 66 66** (free, for anyone up to 18)

Canada	Kids Help Phone, **1-800-668-6868**, or text CONNECT to 686868
Australia	Kids Helpline, **1800 55 1800** (ages 5 to 25)
New Zealand	Youthline, **0800 376 633**, or text 234
US	988 is for every age.

If you're worried about someone

Ask them plainly: "Are you thinking about ending your life?" Studies have found that asking does not put the idea in someone's head, and talking about it may even ease it. Listen, stay with them if you can, and call or text one of the lines above together. Book 3, Chapter 7, page 113 says more about helping someone in a crisis, and Book 2, Chapter 3, page 51 about worry, low mood and when to get help.

This book is general education, not a crisis service. The website's tools keep what you type on your own device, so nobody there can see it or reply to it. The numbers were checked in October 2026. Numbers can change; findahelpline.com keeps an up-to-date list.

1

BOOK 1 · CHAPTER 1

Know yourself: then, where your lens came from

Why you expect what you expect, and how the rules you picked up growing up still make small decisions for you today.

IN THIS CHAPTER

1. You're not one thing
2. Your lens came from somewhere
3. Each stage of growing up asks its own question
4. When something happened matters
5. Some old answers were learned without all the facts
6. An old rule can read other people for you
7. Write down the rulebook from home
8. You get to choose which rules to keep
9. What you carry forward is yours
10. You, in all your relationships
11. Common mix-ups

SUNDAY, 10:15AM

Your partner is still in bed and the kitchen is a mess. Before you have had a single thought, you feel it. Of course it's always you. Nobody said that, but in the house you grew up in, whoever noticed the mess cleaned it, and that old rule has just made a decision on your behalf.

Across town, Ray's house has been quiet since his wife died, and nobody will see the dishes. He still can't sit down until every one of them is washed and put away, because a rule from the home he grew up in is still keeping watch.

01

You're not one thing.

A reaction usually comes from three places at once. Part of it is how you are built, your wiring, which stays much the same. Part is what life taught you, patterns that can soften over time. And part is the kind of day you are having, which passes. This chapter is about the middle layer, the patterns life taught you, and Chapter 2 (page 25) looks at the other two.

A grandmother snaps when her grown-up son is late for Sunday lunch. Some of that is her wiring, because she has always liked things on time. Some is an old rule that lateness means you don't care, and some is the bad night's sleep she had. She could tell him, "Some of this is me being tired, and some of it is an old thing. Give me a minute." The next time you react strongly, it is worth asking whether the reaction is mostly wiring, something you learned or simply today.

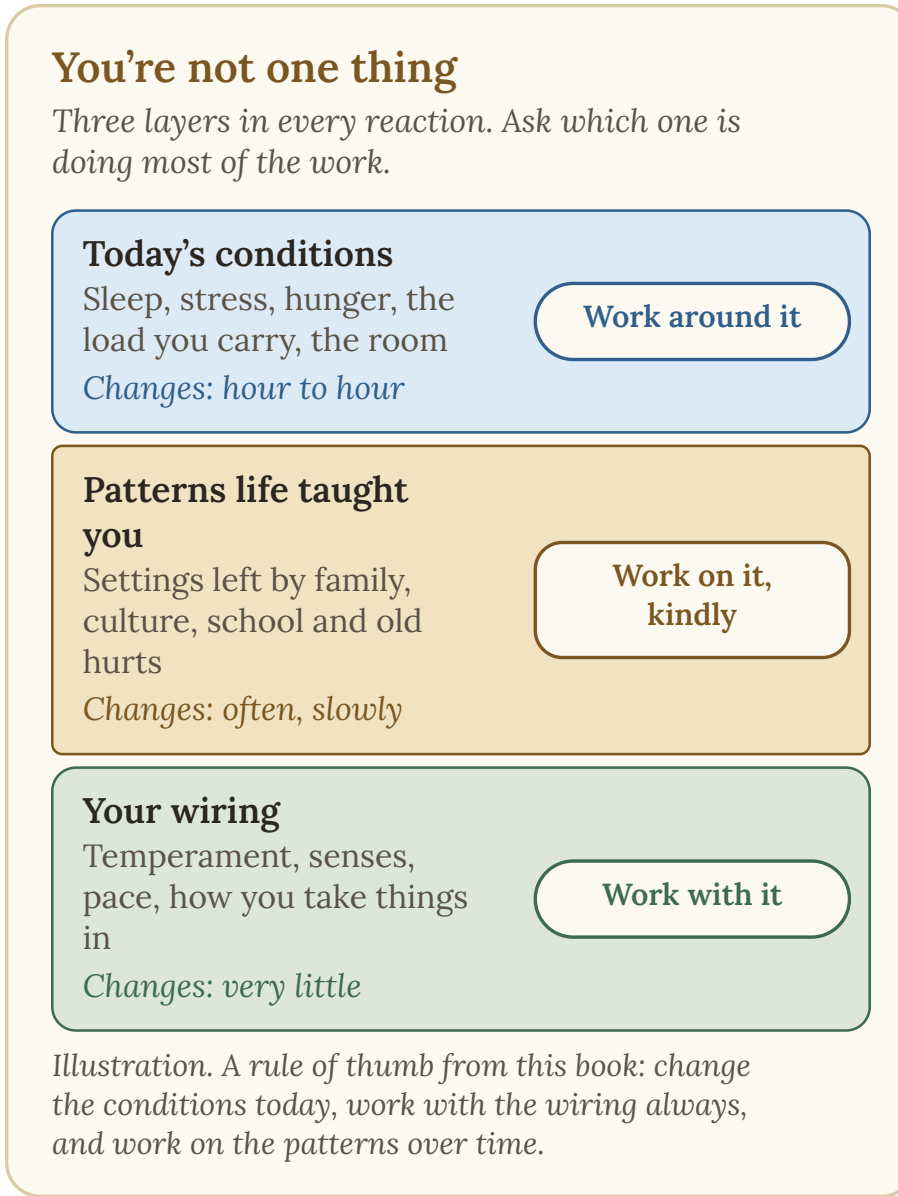


FIGURE 1 Three layers in every reaction. Each one changes at a different speed and needs a different move.

02

Your lens came from somewhere.

Family, school, friends, culture, money at home and what you watched all taught you what to expect of yourself, of other people and of how a good partner, parent or friend behaves. By adulthood your lens no longer feels like a lens, because it feels like simply seeing. One friend grew up with big birthday parties and another with quiet ones, so a small dinner out feels hurtful to one of them and perfect to the other. Neither is being unreasonable, and "In my family this was a big deal. What was it like in yours?" usually clears the air.

Pick one thing you think everyone does and ask someone how their family did it. Where your lens came from walks through the idea gently, and you can read one section and stop.



TIDBIT

Tidbit wants you to know: the rules from home aren't good or bad, they're just yours to have a good sniff at. A fun first look is how you like to talk.

TOOL **How you connect: the 2-minute style quiz** ·
spreadloveandacceptance.com/wavelength

SCAN TO OPEN



TOOL
Old rules, new choices
spreadloveandacceptance.com/growing-up



TOOL
How you connect: the 2-minute style quiz
spreadloveandacceptance.com/wavelength

03

Each stage of growing up asks its own question.

A small child is asking whether the world is safe and whether they can do things for themselves. Later the questions become whether they are capable, where they belong and whether they can be close to someone without losing themselves. Later still, adults ask what they are building and whether their life has meant something. The ages are rough and people move at their own pace, but the answers you landed on can become understandings you keep using as an adult. Someone who moved schools four times as a teenager may still feel like the outsider at every new job, and may catch themselves thinking that part of them is still asking whether they belong.

Read the questions again and notice which one still feels loud for you. Noticing is enough for now.

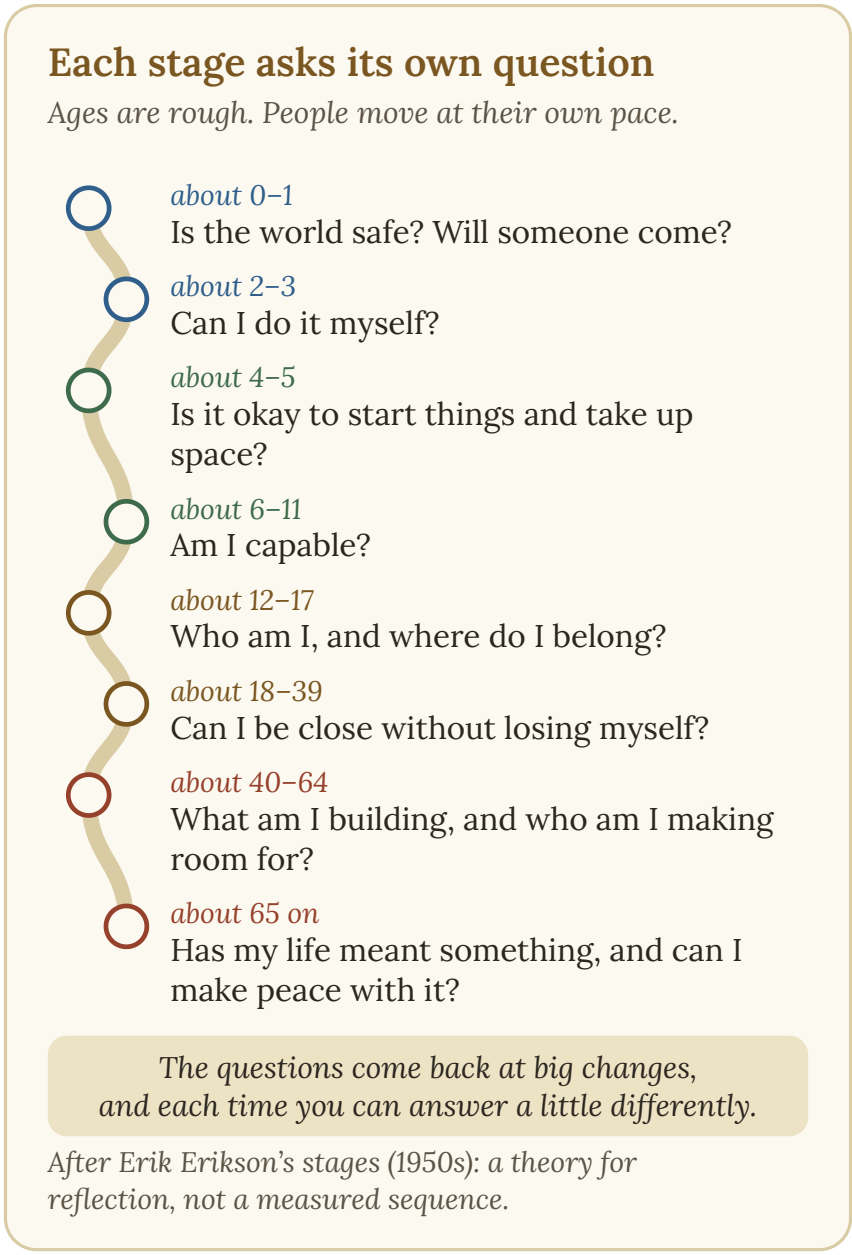


FIGURE 2 Each stage of life asks its own question. The ages are rough, and the questions come back at big changes (after Erik Erikson).

04

When something happened matters.

An experience that touches the question you were answering at the time tends to go deeper. A house move at four is mostly about new routines, while a move at fourteen, right in the middle of wondering where you belong, can leave a longer feeling of being the outsider. Two adult siblings remember their parents' divorce quite differently. One was six and remembers a new bedroom and a new bus route, and the other was fifteen and remembers feeling torn in half. Both memories are true, and they go some way to explaining why the two of them still argue about that year (see Family rifts).

Deeper isn't permanent, though, because people keep learning all their lives. Think of one big change from growing up, and ask how old you were and what you were trying to work out at the time.

SCAN TO OPEN

ONLINE
Family rifts
spreadloveandacceptance
.com/family-rifts

05

Some old answers were learned without all the facts.

Many people carry beliefs like "I'm only okay when I'm useful", "my needs are a burden" or "mistakes mean I'm bad". A child often can't know what was going on for the grown-ups and only knows how it felt. As an adult you are allowed to look again with the full picture, and looking again doesn't mean deciding it was all fine, because some things really were not okay. A foster carer who learned as a girl that her needs were a burden finds it hard to ask for respite, a

planned break while someone else cares for the children, even when she is worn out. An old voice tells her not to ask, while the adult in her knows that asking is fair.

Write down one old belief about yourself, and under it write what you would tell a friend who believed the same thing.

06

An old rule can read other people for you.

If silence at home meant anger, a partner's quiet evening can feel like trouble on the way. An expectation that nobody ever said out loud can't be agreed to either, so the other person can only miss it, whether it is "if you loved me, you'd just know" or "whoever notices, does it". Each of these is somebody's family rule. When a housemate leaves without saying goodbye, someone raised in a quiet, angry house may assume she is upset, when she may simply be late for a shift.

This week, when you catch yourself guessing what someone's silence means, try asking instead, perhaps with "When you went quiet earlier, I wasn't sure what it meant. Is everything okay?"



PROFESSOR PUDDLES

When an old rule jumps in before you've had a chance to think, you don't have to argue with it. Write it down, and look at it again on a calm day.

TOOL **Old rules, new choices** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/growing-up

SCAN TO OPEN

TOOL
Old rules, new choices
spreadloveandacceptance
.com/growing-up

07

Write down the rulebook from home.

Finish these six lines the way your childhood home would have finished them. “In my family, love looked like…” “When someone was upset, we…” “The jobs were split like this…” “Resting was okay when…” “Asking for help meant…” “The unforgivable thing was…” The rulebook page has room to write them, and nothing is saved anywhere except on your own device. Two partners from different faiths once did this and both wrote that holidays belonged to their family, which finally explained why every December had been so hard (see Two faiths, one family).

Finishing a single line today is plenty, and the others can wait. If you share one, you might say, “Here’s a rule I grew up with. I’m not saying it’s right. I just want you to know it’s there.”

FILLED-IN EXAMPLE 1

The rulebook from home
Nadia, on her own

Your rulebook from home

Write a few words on each line, the way the home you grew up in would have finished it. Skip any line you like. Then, for each one,

ask: do I still want this rule?

1. In my family, love looked like…
Doing things. Dad fixed your bike; nobody said it.

Do I still want this rule?

Keep (*Soften*) Drop

2. When someone was upset, we…
Went quiet and waited for it to pass.

Do I still want this rule?

Keep (*Soften*) Drop

3. The jobs were split like this…
Mum noticed, planned and remembered. Dad did the big jobs.

Do I still want this rule?

Keep Soften (*Drop*)

4. Resting was okay when…
Everything else was done.

Do I still want this rule?

Keep Soften (*Drop*)

5. Asking for help meant…
You hadn't planned well enough.

Do I still want this rule?

Keep Soften (*Drop*)

6. The unforgivable thing was…
Breaking a promise.

Do I still want this rule?

(*Keep*) Soften Drop

Fill in your own: The rulebook from home

SCAN TO OPEN

ONLINE
rulebook page
spreadloveandacceptance
.com/growing-up

ONLINE
Two faiths, one family
spreadloveandacceptance
.com/two-faiths

08

You get to choose which rules to keep.

For each line of your rulebook, ask whether you still want that rule. When a reaction feels bigger than the moment, try a one-minute lens check once you have settled. Where did you learn this, how old does it feel, and is it true here, with this person, now? What would the adult you choose? A team leader notices that her old rule about mistakes makes her hide problems from her manager, so she writes a new one on a sticky note above her desk, saying that mistakes are information and the team fixes them together.

Pick one rule from your list and write the version you would like to live by, in the form "I used to think ___. Now I'm choosing ___." Later you can swap rulebooks with someone you trust and choose shared rules on purpose.

09

What you carry forward is yours.

You couldn't control the home you grew up in, what other people did or what you learned before you had all the facts. What is in your hands now is smaller and stronger. It includes which old rules you keep, how you treat yourself about them and where you spend your energy today, and that includes people. Give your time and care where they are met with care, and let one-sided effort shrink back to what feels fair, so that you still have something left to give.

Someone living on their own always plans the meetups with one old friend, who never asks back. They stop chasing, send a warm "I'd love to see you. Let me know when works for you," and find they see more of the friends who reply (see Always the one reaching out?). Is there a relationship where you give far more than comes back? You could give a little less there this month. (If you are afraid of someone, this isn't about managing them. Not safe at home? (spreadloveandacceptance.com/safety) has people to talk to.)



FIGURE 3 Where your lens came from, how you run today and who you are becoming, in one picture. You choose what you carry forward.

SCAN TO OPEN



ONLINE
Always the one reaching out?
spreadloveandacceptance.com/friends



ONLINE
Not safe at home?
spreadloveandacceptance.com/safety

TUESDAY MORNING

Two people get the same text, asking whether they can talk tonight. One is pleased, because she likes knowing ahead. The other feels his stomach drop, because in the home he grew up in, "we need to talk" meant trouble, and he spends the whole afternoon rehearsing answers to a conversation that turns out to be about a holiday.

You, in all your relationships

Your old rules go wherever you go, starting with how you treat yourself, since the voice you use after a mistake is often an old one. At home they decide who notices, who plans and what quiet means, and two housemates can find they are living by two rulebooks about mess, noise and guests. In families, old roles like the helper or the peacemaker switch back on at the front door. At work, someone who was praised mainly for being useful may say yes to everything and then quietly resent it, until seeing the old rule lets them pause before the next yes. After a breakup old rules can get louder, which is a good time to look at them gently (see On my own). Help by relationship lists pages for many situations.

SCAN TO OPEN

ONLINE
On my own
spreadloveandacceptance
.com/on-my-own

ONLINE
Help by relationship
spreadloveandacceptance
.com/by-relationship

Common mix-ups

- **"Looking back means blaming my family."** Looking back is about understanding. Many of the adults who raised us were working with their own lenses too, and if that doesn't fit your story, you don't have to make it fit.
- **"If it started in childhood, I'm stuck with it."** Many old patterns soften with awareness, safety and practice, and some leave a lasting sensitivity you learn to carry and explain.
- **"Every big reaction is an old wound."** Often it is just a full tank. Book 4, Chapter 3 (page 49) helps you tell leftover stress from this-moment stress.
- **"If they won't look at their rules, there's no point looking at mine."** Knowing your own rules changes how you react, even if nobody else ever reads a word of this.

A note on care: This part looks back at growing up. It is general education, not a diagnosis or therapy, and it can't tell you what anyone has. Not every home felt calm or kind, so take only what is useful. If looking back feels heavy, you can stop and come back another day, or explore it with a qualified professional, if and when you want that. Nothing here is required, and nothing you write needs to be shared.

If you want to go on, think of one "always" or "never" you felt this week and ask whose voice it sounds like and how old you felt. Then write one sentence that the adult you would rather live by, and keep it somewhere you will see it. Where your lens came from, Roots & Wings and Know your own wiring go further.

SCAN TO OPEN



TOOL
Old rules, new choices
spreadloveandacceptance.com/growing-up



ONLINE
Roots & Wings
spreadloveandacceptance.com/growing-up



ONLINE
Know your own wiring
spreadloveandacceptance.com/know-yourself

WHAT TO REMEMBER

- ✓ You're not one thing.
- ✓ Each stage of growing up asks its own question.
- ✓ Some old answers were learned without all the facts.
- ✓ Write down the rulebook from home.
- ✓ What you carry forward is yours.

THIS CONNECTS TO

Book 3, Chapter 3 · How we see each other
How a lens shapes what you notice in other people
Understanding Each Other, page 45

Book 3, Chapter 4 · Attachment, trust and belonging
How early trust and attachment carry into adult life
Understanding Each Other, page 61

Chapter 6 · Personality, temperament and change
Which parts are temperament, and which can change
page 93

Book 2, Chapter 5 · Healing after hurt
Making peace with what happened, and when to get help
Heal and Steady, page 87

PUT IT TO USE

The self path: see where your lens came from
spreadloveandacceptance.com/self-path

Go deeper (free online) The full chapter, with the research, more examples and more to try: spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/self-1-then-in-depth

2

BOOK 1 · CHAPTER 2

Know yourself: now, your wiring, your weather and your words

Why the same words can land differently on different days and in different people, and how to understand today's you well enough to say what helps.

IN THIS CHAPTER

1. Today is made of two layers you can work with
2. Know how you like to be spoken to
3. Check your weather before you speak
4. Ask where this feeling is coming from
5. Plan what settles you on a calm day
6. Your needs and limits are information, not demands
7. Being wired differently is not being wrong
8. Explain yourself without over-sharing
9. Do your part, and only your part
10. You, in all your relationships
11. Common mix-ups

SUNDAY, 7:50PM

A friend asks whether you are okay, and you say you're fine. The truth is that you can't tell whether you are fine, tired or quietly bothered by something, and you couldn't explain it to yourself, let alone to her.

01

Today is made of two layers you can work with.

Your wiring is the lasting part, made up of your temperament, your pace, your senses and how you take in words. You work *with* it by building a setup that suits you. Today's conditions are the passing part, such as sleep, hunger, how much you are carrying, the room and the time of day, and you work *around* them by eating first, sleeping on it or talking tomorrow. Mixing the two up is where a lot of frustration comes from. (Chapter 1 (page 9) covers the third layer, the patterns life taught you.)

For example, a dad who works nights finds the school-run chatter unbearable at eight in the morning, and for a while he wonders whether he is cut out for parenting at all. When he swaps to the afternoon pick-up, the same chatter is fun again (see Different hours).

YOU COULD SAY

"It's the hour, honestly. Can we talk after I've slept?"

TRY THIS.

Write down one thing that always bothers you, which is probably wiring, and one that only bothers you when you are tired.



PROFESSOR PUDDLES

Your wiring stays the same from day to day. Your weather doesn't. A one-minute check in the morning helps you tell the two apart.

TOOL **My weather today** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/quick-checks

SCAN TO OPEN

ONLINE
Different hours
spreadloveandacceptance
.com/different-hours

TOOL
My weather today
spreadloveandacceptance
.com/quick-checks

02

Know how you like to be spoken to.

Your pace, your tone, how much you need spelled out and what silence means to you all change how words land. How you connect helps you find words for how you think, talk and listen, and gives you a four-letter Wave Code that is meant as a light-hearted description. The “How to talk to me” card puts how you take in words on one page, which you can share before a hard talk.

A grandmother loves phone calls and her grandson loves texts, and for a year each thought the other was being distant. Once they said how they like to talk, they settled on a Sunday call with texts in between.

THIS WEEK.

Finish the sentence “I take things in best when…” and keep it for your card.

FILLED-IN EXAMPLE 2

“How to talk to me” card

Ife, made on her own to give to a friend

Your card

Pick what is usually true for you. Add a few words where the

buttons are not enough. Leave a line blank if it does not apply.

Who it's for

A partner Family *A friend* Work (a manager or coworker)

Name on the card, optional

Ife

WIRING CARD · NOT A DIAGNOSIS

How I receive things best
In writing. One thing at a time.

I take words
Literally when it matters, tone when it is light.

Give me time to answer
A few minutes.

If I go quiet, it means
I'm thinking.

Please avoid
Long texts or many topics at once.

A request lands best as
The ask in the first sentence.

Applies more strictly when I am running low. Not a contract, and not a label. Change it when it stops being true.

Fill in your own: "How to talk to me" card

SCAN TO OPEN

TOOL
How you connect: the 2-minute style quiz
spreadloveandacceptance.com/wavelength

TOOL
How you connect: how to talk to me
spreadloveandacceptance.com/wiring-card

03

Check your weather before you speak.

Every conversation runs through your own state first. Book 4, Chapter 3 (page 49) looks closely at the stress tank in a shared home, so this chapter only adds the self side, a one-minute reading on your own before you decide what a hard moment means. My weather today is the quick check, and How much are you carrying? is a fuller one on a short worksheet.

For example, a long-distance couple notice that their difficult calls always fall at the end of one partner's late shift, so they move serious talks to weekend mornings (see Long distance).

> WORDS YOU COULD USE
>
> "I'm running on empty tonight. Can we pick this up tomorrow morning?"

ONE STATE, MANY WORDS. The chapters and tools use a few everyday pictures for one thing, how much room you have today. They describe the same state in different ways.

- **The three states** (Book 2, Chapter 1 (page 9) calls them the ladder) are calm and connected, revved up, and running on empty.
- **My weather today** uses sky words for the same three. *Clear* is calm and connected, *gusty* is revved up, and *fogged in* is running on empty. Its *pressure* (light, building or heavy) is how much you were already carrying.
- **The stress tank** is the score from How much are you carrying?, from 0 to 1, where higher means fuller.
- **The battery** is the other side of the tank, the energy you have left, so a full tank means a low battery.

"Gusty", "revved up", "a fairly full tank" and "a low battery" can all describe the same afternoon, so use whichever words suit you.

FILLED-IN EXAMPLE 3

My weather today

Joel, on his own, after a short night

Check today's weather

The sky

Clear: Calm and connected | *Gusty: Revved up* | Fogged in: Running on empty

Who you'll mostly be around today

A partner | Family | A co-parent | Roommates | Coworkers | Someone I care for | Friends | *Mostly on my own*

The pressure

Light *Building* Heavy

Ground conditions

Haven't eaten in a while Thirsty In pain or unwell Been still all day

Too much noise or light Running on caffeine Screens since I woke up

Last night's sleep

Barely slept *Short night* About enough Properly rested

People load

Barely any A normal amount *A lot* Nonstop, no gaps

What's blowing in

Work Money Kids or caring Health Family The house

One conversation Something I can't name

What would actually help in the next hour?

Space *Food or water* Rest *To move* To be heard A plan

Company Quiet Someone to take something off me

YOUR FORECAST

Gusty today
Revved up · Some room today

Pace
go gently, settle first

It's gusty. You're revved up. That energy is useful for doing something physical, but it is poor weather for big decisions.

You said what would help is food or water and to move. Arrange that before anything else.

Overall: some room today. There is less room than usual, so spend it carefully.

If you want to send someone a line: "I'm a bit wound up today, so I'll keep replies short. It isn't about you."

Fill in your own: My weather today

SCAN TO OPEN



TOOL
My weather today
spreadloveandacceptance
.com/quick-checks



ONLINE
Long distance
spreadloveandacceptance
.com/long-distance

04

Ask where this feeling is coming from.

First name the feeling, perhaps as “tight, annoyed, a bit scared”. Then ask whether it is the size of the moment or feels older, which layer it belongs to, and what it needs right now, whether that is food, space, a heads-up, reassurance or a proper conversation later. It takes a minute and works best once the first wave has passed. When a coworker asks “Quick question?” and your heart races, you might name the feeling as jumpy, recognise an old boss in it as well as a busy day, and ask for five minutes before you answer.

When feelings are hard to name. For some people, “What are you feeling?” is a hard question most days, and on bad days it is almost impossible. They notice a racing heart or a heavy stomach but can’t tell whether it is worry, anger or hunger. Psychologists call this *alexithymia*, which means “no words for feelings”. It is a trait that runs from a little to a lot, it is common, especially among autistic people, and it is not an illness. The feelings are there and the words come slowly. It helps to start with the body (“tight chest, skipped lunch”), to choose between two words (“more tired or more annoyed?”), to use the three sky words in place of feeling words, and to give it time. “I’ll tell you tomorrow” is a real answer.

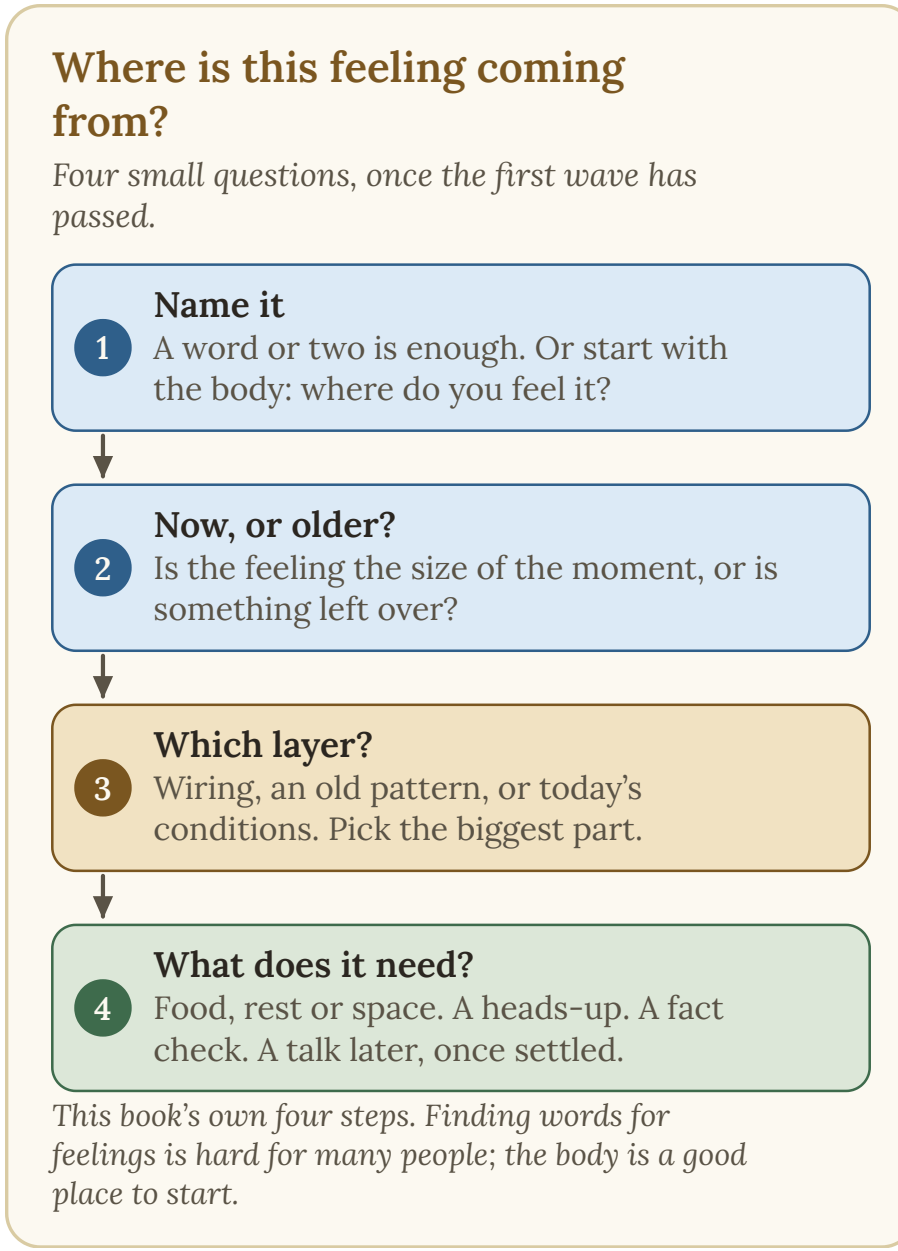


FIGURE 4 A four-step self-check for a feeling that is bigger than you expected. Do it once the first wave has passed.

05

Plan what settles you on a calm day.

The middle of being wound up is a bad time to work out what helps. The Calm-Down Kit is a plan you make while you are calm, covering what tends to set you off, two calming steps and one sentence for stepping away that says when you will be back. It is for you and never for the other person.

A teenager makes a plan with herself for rows with her mum. When one heats up, she says, “I need ten minutes in my room, then I’ll come back,” and twelve minutes later she comes back down to the kitchen.

ONE SMALL STEP.

On a calm day, write your one stepping-away sentence, including when you will be back.



SUGARFOOT

Sugarfoot’s tip: make your calm-down plan on a slow, sunny day, maybe with a cup of tea. It’s much easier than making it in the middle of a storm.

WORKPAPER WP-11 **The Calm-Down Kit** · free to print
· spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/fill/wp-11

SCAN TO OPEN

WORKPAPER WP-11 · free to print
The Calm-Down Kit
spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/fill/wp-11

06

Your needs and limits are information, not demands.

What helps you, what matters to you and what you have left are facts about you, and said kindly they let other people plan around you. “A heads-up helps me.” “I can take this one, but not that one.” “I’m low today. Can we talk tomorrow?” You don’t need to justify a need, either. A reason is a kindness you can offer when you want to. In a home with three partners, Quinn needs an hour alone after work, and once he has said so, calmly and once, it stops being a mystery and becomes part of the plan.

Two workpapers from other chapters can help. Who did what, from Book 4, Chapter 1 (page 9), has ready-made kind ways to say no, and Say it so it lands, from Book 4, Chapter 4 (page 69), helps you turn a raw reaction into a plain request.

SOMETHING TO TRY.

Write one need you have never said out loud, and practise saying it as a fact without apologising for it.

07

Being wired differently is not being wrong.

Some people take in words, noise, change and feelings differently from the way most social customs were built. That is wiring, which you can understand, plan around and get support for if you choose. A woman with ADHD keeps forgetting plans with a friend and used to call herself hopeless. Now she says what helps, which is a text the day before, and she turns up (see Neurodivergent relationships).

A mix-up runs both ways. When an autistic and a non-autistic person misread each other, it is easy to blame the autistic person. The *double empathy problem*, named by the autistic researcher Damian Milton, is the idea that the gap runs both ways, because

each person reads the other through their own way of communicating and each finds the other hard to read. In one study, a story passed along a chain of autistic people kept as much detail as one passed along non-autistic people, while mixed chains lost detail faster. Wired Differently shows how two differently wired people can each misread the other. Asking "Where did we lose each other?" lets both of you adjust a little.

SCAN TO OPEN

ONLINE
Neurodivergent relationships
spreadloveandacceptance.com/neurodivergent-relationships

ONLINE
Wired Differently
spreadloveandacceptance.com/wired-differently

08

Explain yourself without over-sharing.

Three short sentences cover most moments. "This is how I'm wired. It won't change, but here's what helps." "This is an old alarm. I'm working on it, and here's what helps in the moment." "Today's a low-battery day." You never owe anyone your history, so share the part that helps them help you. A man with a long-term illness tells a new friend, "Some days I have less energy, and if I cancel, it isn't about you," and leaves his medical notes out of it (see When one of you is ill).

SCAN TO OPEN

ONLINE
When one of you is ill
spreadloveandacceptance
.com/when-one-is-ill

09

Do your part, and only your part.

Today you control your words, your effort, your rest, your limits and what you ask for. You don't control someone else's mood, reply, pace or choices, and trying to manage them drains you fast. Do your side well and let go of theirs. It also helps to match energy with energy, meeting warmth with warmth and effort with effort, and giving a little less when you keep giving far more than comes back, because a protected battery is what keeps you kind.

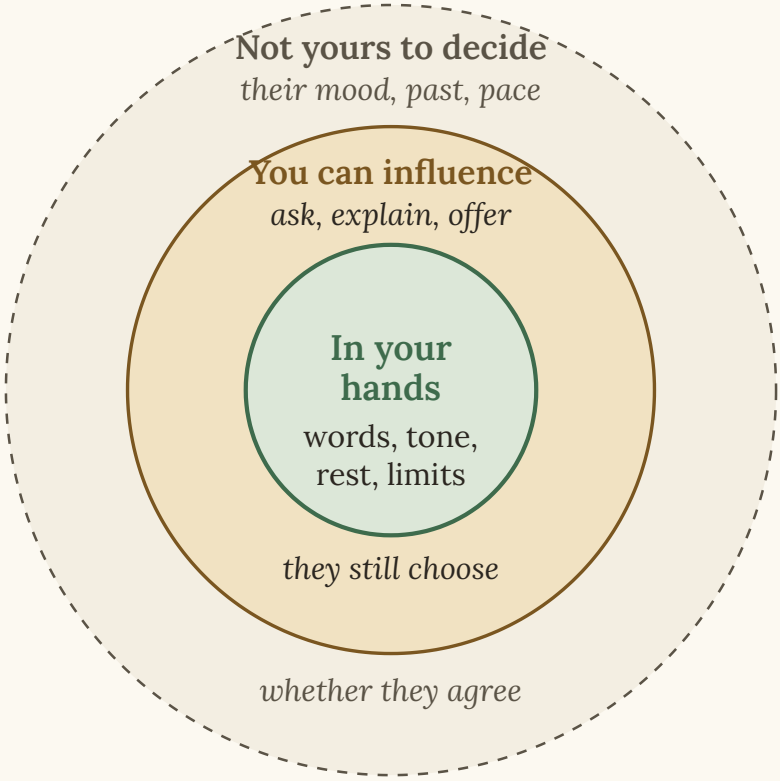
For example, a grown-up daughter has spent years trying to stop her father worrying about her. She can't do that, but she can send a short "Home safe" text after long drives and then let his worry be his (see For grown-up children).

TRY THIS.

Write one thing you keep trying to control that isn't yours, and next to it one thing that is. (If you are afraid of someone, this isn't about managing them. Not safe at home? (spreadloveandacceptance.com/safety) has people to talk to.)

Your circle of control

Spend your energy from the middle out.



Most exhaustion comes from pouring energy into the outer ring.

Illustration.

FIGURE 5 Your circle of control. Spend your energy from the middle out; most exhaustion comes from pouring it into the outer ring.

SCAN TO OPEN



ONLINE
For grown-up children
spreadloveandacceptance
.com/grown-up-children



ONLINE
Not safe at home?
spreadloveandacceptance
.com/safety

FRIDAY, 6:40PM

"Surprise! I've booked us dinner with my cousins tonight." They meant it as a gift. You felt your chest tighten and heard yourself say "Great" in a flat voice. Later, washing up, you wonder whether that was just you, something from years ago or simply the end of a long week, and you suspect it was a bit of all three.

You, in all your relationships

Your wiring and your weather come with you everywhere, starting with how you treat yourself on a hard day, when noticing that you are low comes before deciding that you are failing. Partners can give each other a heads-up, a quiet hour or a better time to talk, and every partner has wiring of their own. With friends and family the question is often how you like to keep in touch and how much you can give this month. At work it may be an agenda ahead or a minute before you answer, and housemates tend to negotiate noise, light and quiet time. If you live on your own, you can build a week that suits how you are built (see On my own).

SCAN TO OPEN



ONLINE
On my own
spreadloveandacceptance
.com/on-my-own

Common mix-ups

- **"Knowing myself means finding the right label."** It is mostly about what helps. The three layers and a Wave Code are everyday words, and neither is a diagnosis.
- **"'That's just how I am' ends the talk."** It may be true, especially for wiring, and it works better as an opening, as in "This is how I'm wired, and here's what helps."
- **"If I tell people how I'm wired, they have to manage me."** Telling them helps their words land. You still do your part, and they still have their own needs.
- **"I'm fine" means I'm fine.** Sometimes it does. It can also mean you have been tired for so long that you stopped noticing, and a quick reading each week shows the baseline you have got used to.

A note on care: This part is general education. It isn't a diagnosis, a test or treatment, and it can't tell you whether you're autistic, have ADHD or anything else, or what anyone else has. If you'd like to understand yourself more deeply, a qualified professional can help, if and when you want that. Nothing here is required, and nothing you try needs to be shared. If talking about any of this with someone ever feels unsafe, or you feel you can't say no, stop and talk with a trained counselor on your own. When someone is afraid of their partner, counseling together isn't advised. Not safe at home? lists free, private hotlines.

To put the chapter to use, pick one reaction you had this week and write one line for each layer, the wiring part, the older part and today's part. Take a one-minute reading of your weather, then write one sentence about what helps you, in your own words, and keep it to yourself for a few days before you share it with one person on a calm day. Know your own wiring (spreadloveandacceptance.com/know-yourself), the "How to talk to me" card and How much are you carrying? are free on the site.

SCAN TO OPEN



ONLINE
Not safe at home?
spreadloveandacceptance.com/safety



ONLINE
Know your own wiring
spreadloveandacceptance.com/know-yourself



TOOL
How you connect: how to talk to me
spreadloveandacceptance.com/wiring-card



WORKPAPER WP-02 · free to print
How much are you carrying?
spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/fill/wp-02

WHAT TO REMEMBER

- ✓ **Today has two layers you can work with.** Work with your wiring, which stays, and around today's conditions, which pass.
- ✓ **Check your state before a hard talk.** Weather, the three states, the stress tank and the battery are different words for how much room you have today.
- ✓ **If a feeling is hard to name, start with the body.** That is common, and it even has a name, alexithymia.
- ✓ **Your needs and limits are information.** Plan what settles you on a calm day, and say what helps in one short sentence.
- ✓ **A mix-up between two different minds runs both ways**, so both people adjust a little.

THIS CONNECTS TO

Chapter 7 · Minds that work differently
Wiring differences: autism, ADHD and the senses page 111

Book 2, Chapter 1 · Stress and the nervous system
Why your weather changes how you hear things Heal and Steady, page 9

Book 4, Chapter 3 · Full tanks and different angles
The stress tank, used between two people Share the Load, page 49

Book 4, Chapter 4 · Two kinds of fair
What fair means when you share the work Share the Load, page 69

PUT IT TO USE



The self path: get to know your wiring
spreadloveandacceptance.com/self-path



How much are you carrying? A quick stress check
Workpaper · free to print
spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/fill/wp-02



Go deeper (free online) The full chapter, with the research, more examples and more to try: spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/self-2-now-in-depth

3

BOOK 1 · CHAPTER 3

Know yourself: next, shaping who you are becoming

You aren't finished, and some of who you become is up to you. This chapter is about choosing a direction and building small steps that still work on a tired day.

IN THIS CHAPTER

1. Start with what matters to you
2. Pick one small goal, in plain words
3. Name what gets in the way
4. Make the step tiny, and repeatable
5. Decide ahead with a simple if-then
6. Ask for support, as information
7. Look back kindly once a month
8. Kindness to yourself is part of the plan
9. Set goals inside your circle, and spend energy where it comes back
10. You, in all your relationships
11. Common mix-ups

IN SHORT

- **Start with what matters to you** in two or three plain words, then pick one small goal you can actually do.
- **Make the step tiny and decide ahead**, as in "If it's after dinner, then I put my shoes on."
- **Ask for support as information**, and look back kindly once a month.
- **A missed day tells you about the plan**, so change the plan and keep going.

- **Set goals inside your circle**, and spend your energy where it comes back.

WEDNESDAY, 9:10PM

You meant to start walking after dinner, and you meant to last week too. Tonight you are tired, the shoes are by the door where you left them on Sunday, and you tell yourself you will begin on Monday.

01

Start with what matters to you.

A goal built on someone else's idea of success is hard to keep up. Before you pick anything, ask what you want your days to be like, and write two or three plain words, such as calm, close to my family, steady or creative. They give you a direction to face rather than a score to reach. How you connect can help you notice what fills you up and what drains you.

For example, after their youngest leaves home, a couple each write two words. Hers are "useful, outdoors" and his are "calm, curious", which suddenly explains why she wants to volunteer at the nature reserve while he wants to dig over the vegetable patch (see Kids grown and gone).

TRY THIS.

Write two plain words for what matters to you right now, in pencil if you like, since you can change them.

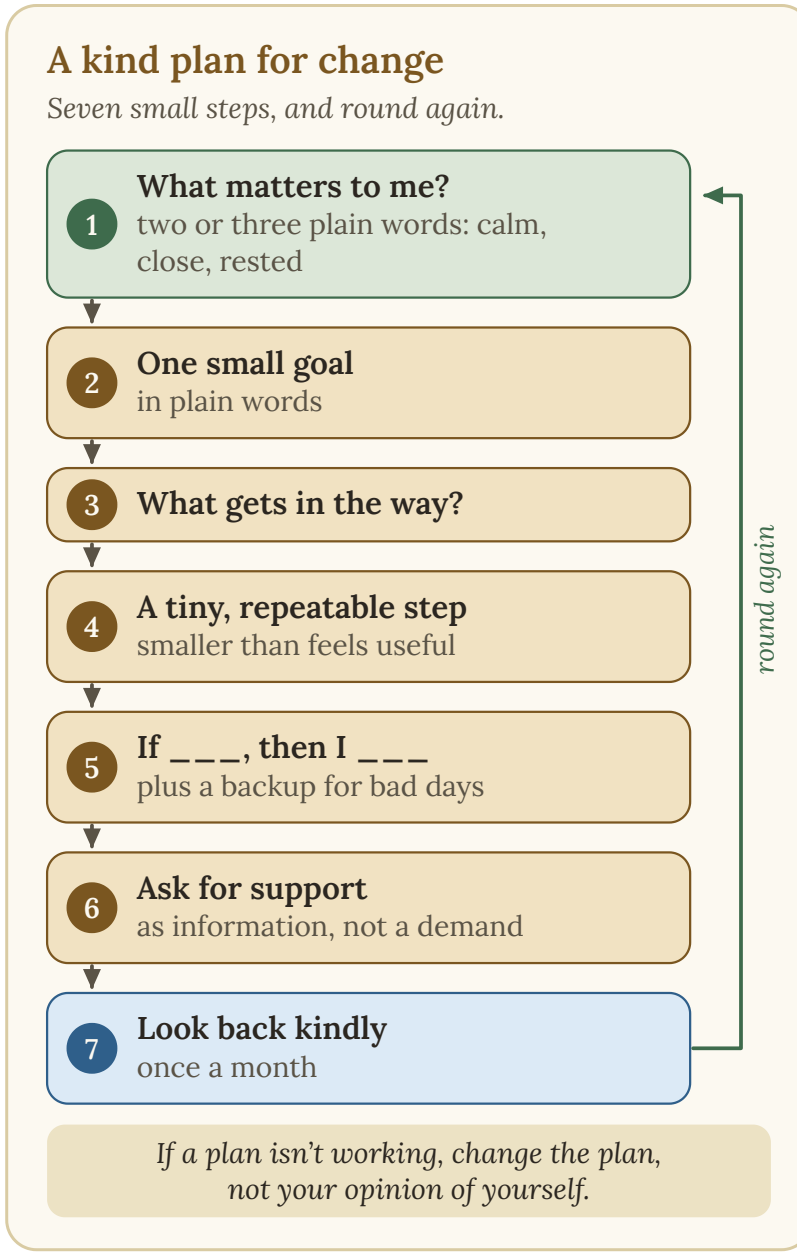


FIGURE 6 A kind plan for change in seven small steps. If the plan isn't working, change the plan, not your opinion of yourself.

SCAN TO OPEN

TOOL
How you connect: the 2-minute style quiz
spreadloveandacceptance.com/wavelength

ONLINE
Kids grown and gone
spreadloveandacceptance.com/empty-nest

02

Pick one small goal, in plain words.

Choose just one, and say it as something you will do. “Walk for ten minutes after dinner” is a goal you can keep, while “get healthier” is a hope. Your own actions are up to you, and how other people respond and how things turn out are not. A student sharing a room in halls wants to be less messy, and as an action it becomes putting her clothes in the basket before bed (see Sharing a room).

THIS WEEK.

Rewrite one wish as something you will do, starting with “I will…”

SCAN TO OPEN

TOOL
Plan it once: room agreement for roommates
spreadloveandacceptance.com/sharing-a-room

03

Name what gets in the way.

Use what you learned in Chapter 1 (page 9) and Chapter 2 (page 25). The obstacle may be your wiring, since a plan that ignores how you are built was made for someone else. It may be an old rule, such as “rest has to be earned”, or simply today’s conditions, like a tired evening. Then change the arrangement and leave yourself alone, for example by moving the step to the morning. A shift worker kept missing his evening run, which had nothing to do with laziness, because his rota changed every week. Once he tied the run to his first day off, he stopped missing it (see Different hours).

SCAN TO OPEN

ONLINE
Different hours
spreadloveandacceptance
.com/different-hours

04

Make the step tiny, and repeatable.

Make it small enough to survive your worst week, so that “put my shoes on” counts. Tie it to something you already do, and do it often. The 90-second daily check-in in Book 3, Chapter 1 (page 9) works on the same idea, that something small and frequent lasts longer than something big and rare, and Ten-minute start shows how small a whole path can be. Someone on their own after a breakup wants to get back out there, and the tiny step they choose is one message to one friend every Sunday (see On my own).

ONE SMALL STEP.
Shrink your step until it takes less than two minutes.



TIDBIT

Tidbit wants you to know: tiny steps count, even the wobbly ones! If you like a game, there's one where each small kind act moves the ball up the field.

TOOL **Gentle games: the Re-check Drive (calm football)** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/recheck-drive

SCAN TO OPEN

TOOL
Ten-minute start
spreadloveandacceptance.com/start-in-10-minutes

ONLINE
On my own
spreadloveandacceptance.com/on-my-own

TOOL
Gentle games: the Re-check Drive (calm football)
spreadloveandacceptance.com/recheck-drive

05

Decide ahead with a simple if-then.

"If it's after dinner, then I put my shoes on." Deciding ahead means one decision fewer on a tired day, which is the same idea as the Calm-Down Kit, made while you are calm. A separated parent who wants calmer handovers decides that when she pulls up outside, she will take three slow breaths before she gets out of the car (see Co-parenting). If a plan isn't working, change the plan.

SOMETHING TO TRY.

Write one if-then, using a cue that happens every day, such as the kettle, the front door or brushing your teeth.

FILLED-IN EXAMPLE 4

The Calm-Down Kit, just for me

Nell, on her own

The Calm-Down Kit

Your name
Nell

Date
11 October 2026

Part A: What tends to start it

What tends to start it	How it shows up in my body first
A long message from my sister late at night	*Tight chest, typing fast*
Plans changed with no warning	*Jaw, hot face*

Part A: My two defaults

First default
Walking it out

Second, if the first isn't available
Asymmetric breathing (4 in, 6 out)

Part A: My pause line

In my words
I'm at capacity. I'm going to step away for twenty minutes, and I'll answer properly after that.

My pause plan (yours to share, if you like)

My pause word or signal
"Back in a bit"

The shortest break I take
20 minutes

How I set the time to come back
I text a time, the same day

The first sentence when I come back
"Thanks for waiting. I can think straight now."

Part B: In the moment

Say your pause word or line, then do your first calming step. Nothing in this kit works by cold, pain or shock, and none of it is treatment.

Part C: Coming back

Time	What I did	How I feel now
9:40 pm	*Walking it out*	*Still hot*
10:05 pm	*Asymmetric breathing (4 in, 6 out)*	*Settled enough*

WHERE THAT LEAVES YOU

Next
Settled enough: pick things back up, at the time you named. When you come back, start with one small, simple task, like putting the dishes away.

Next small action
Reply to my sister's message, one line

If you put it off: when you'll pick it back up
Tomorrow after lunch

☑ I'm going with this
Fill in your own: The Calm-Down Kit (Just me)

SCAN TO OPEN



WORKPAPER WP-11 · free to print
The Calm-Down Kit
spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/fill/wp-11



TOOL
Plan it once: handoff bag for two homes
spreadloveandacceptance.com/co-parenting



WORKPAPER WP-11 · free to print
The Calm-Down Kit
spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/fill/wp-11

06

Ask for support, as information.

Tell one person what you are trying and what would help, as in "I'm trying to walk after dinner. Could you ask me about it on Sunday?" They can say no, and you don't need their agreement to start. A woman caring for her husband after a stroke asks her brother whether he could sit with him on Thursday afternoons so she can swim, and because the request is so specific, it is easy for him to answer. Some goals are better shared with a qualified professional, and asking for one is a sensible step whenever you want it.

TRY THIS.

Name one person and one small, specific thing they could do. (If someone uses your goals to check up on you or control you, Not safe at home? (spreadloveandacceptance.com/safety) has people to talk to.)

SCAN TO OPEN

ONLINE
Not safe at home?
spreadloveandacceptance.com/safety

07

Look back kindly once a month.

This is the monthly look-back from Book 4, Chapter 5 (page 93), pointed at yourself. Once a month, take ten minutes to ask what went well and what kept slipping, and whether the gap was in the plan, in how much you had to give that month or in one unusual week. Old misses don't get added up, and the only question is what

to try next month. A grandmother raising her two grandchildren looks back and sees that bedtime is working and homework isn't, so next month she tries homework at the kitchen table straight after a snack.

THIS WEEK.

Put ten minutes in your calendar for the first of next month.



PROFESSOR PUDDLES

Your monthly look is the solo version of the monthly look-back for people who share a home. Borrow its two questions if you like: what kept slipping, and what would have made it easier?

WORKPAPER WP-04 **What keeps coming back?** · free to print
· spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/fill/wp-04

SCAN TO OPEN

WORKPAPER WP-04 · free to print
What keeps coming back?
spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/fill/wp-04

08

Kindness to yourself is part of the plan.

A plan that needs you to be harsh with yourself rests on what is sometimes called the second arrow. The first arrow is the slip itself, and the second is the telling-off you give yourself afterwards, which hurts more and helps less. Rest belongs inside the plan, and you can shrink a goal, change it or drop it at any time. A sixteen-year-old who planned to revise every night misses three nights and calls himself useless. His grandmother asks what

he would tell his best friend, and he shrinks the goal to twenty minutes before tea.

ONE SMALL STEP.

Next time you miss a step, say one sentence to yourself that you would say to a friend.

09

Set goals inside your circle, and spend energy where it comes back.

A goal that depends on someone else changing is really a wish. Shape each goal around what you can do, such as asking once, kindly, by Friday. You might wish your adult sister called more often, which sits outside your circle, while calling her on the first Sunday of each month and telling her you would love her to call too sits inside it. Then budget your energy like the limited thing it is, putting more into the people and plans that give back and less into the ones that only take, so that you keep going long enough to reach the goal.

SOMETHING TO TRY.

Rewrite one goal that depends on someone else, so that the next step is yours.

THE FIRST OF THE MONTH

You open your notes. Of the four small things you tried, two have stuck and two quietly stopped somewhere around the second week. You still don't know why the Saturday swim fell away, and you write a question mark next to it for next month.

You, in all your relationships

A goal for yourself often touches the people around you, and small steps work everywhere. With a partner, offer one small habit rather than demanding one, and with friends, one message a week can be enough. In a family it might be a regular call, a visit you can keep up or a first step after years apart (see Reaching out). At work it could be one comment per meeting, and with money, one small saving habit you control.

FILLED-IN EXAMPLE 5

The self path, step by step

Sam, on their own, two weeks in

The path, step by step

Step	Where it's at
Check your battery	*Done ✓*
Get to know your wiring	*Done ✓*
See where your lens came from	*Done ✓*
Plan what settles you	Not yet
Find words for what you feel	Not yet
Practice kind ways to say no	Not yet

Come back gently, once a week

Pick a day and a time, and add a ten-minute reminder to your own calendar. It repeats every week and just says "10 minutes for me".

Day	Time
Sunday	*7:30 pm*

WHAT HAPPENS NEXT

The next step is Plan what settles you: the Calm-Down Kit. Three steps done is three steps done; the rest will still be here next week.

Fill in your own: The self path

SCAN TO OPEN

ONLINE
Reaching out
spreadloveandacceptance.com/family-rifts

ONLINE
The self path
spreadloveandacceptance.com/self-path

Common mix-ups

- **"A goal has to be big to count."** Small and repeatable is what survives a bad week, and big goals are often just many small ones.
- **"If I know myself, I should be able to change anything."** Wiring stays, so the aim is a goal that fits how you are built.
- **"Asking for support means I couldn't manage alone."** Asking gives other people the information they need to help.
- **"I'll start on Monday."** A fresh start can help, but today's tiny version counts too.

> **A note on care:** This part is general education. It isn't therapy, coaching or medical advice, and it can't promise any result. Goals about your health, money, work or a hard stretch in life may deserve a qualified professional, and there's no shame in asking for one. Nothing here is required, and nothing you write needs to be shared. If a goal ever starts to feel like a weight, you can shrink it or put it down.

To start, write two plain words for what matters to you, one small goal as something you will do, the tiniest first step and one if-then. Then put a ten-minute look-back on the calendar for a month from now. Your self-discovery path and Ten-minute start are free on the site.

SCAN TO OPEN



ONLINE
Your self-discovery path
spreadloveandacceptance.com/self-path



TOOL
Ten-minute start
spreadloveandacceptance.com/start-in-10-minutes

THIS CONNECTS TO

Book 2, Chapter 7 · Values, meaning and a good life — Heal and Steady, page 121
Finding out what matters to you

Book 2, Chapter 6 · Habits and change — Heal and Steady, page 105
Why tiny steps and if-then plans work

Book 4, Chapter 5 · The monthly look-back — Share the Load, page 93
The same monthly look, done together

Chapter 5 · Self-worth, shame and self-compassion — page 79
A kinder inner voice when a step slips

PUT IT TO USE



The self path, step by step
spreadloveandacceptance.com/self-path



The Calm-Down Kit: a plan for heated moments
Workpaper · free to print
spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/fill/wp-11



Go deeper (free online) The full chapter, with the research, more examples and more to try: spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/self-3-next-in-depth

4

BOOK 1 · CHAPTER 4

How feelings work: signals, the body, and naming what you feel

What feelings are for, where they start, and why putting a name to one can make it easier to carry, whether you are on your own, at home, with friends or at work.

IN THIS CHAPTER

1. A feeling is a signal, not a verdict
2. Feelings start in the body
3. Naming a feeling helps you hold it
4. More words, better tools
5. Feelings come in layers
6. Feelings rise and pass like waves
7. Feelings spread between people
8. If you weren't brought up to talk about feelings
9. Feeling it isn't the same as doing it
10. In everyday life
11. Common mix-ups
12. If you want to help someone else with this
13. When to get more help
14. Workpapers, tools and reading on this site
15. More for your situation

WHY THE TOOLS WORK. Two tools in other chapters rest on what this one explains.

- **My weather today and the daily check-in** (Chapter 2 (page 25); Book 3, Chapter 1 (page 9)) ask for one word about how you are. Naming a feeling turns its volume down a little, and a daily word catches feelings while they are still small.
- **Say it so it lands** (Book 4, Chapter 4 (page 69)) asks you to describe a feeling, because "I felt let down" is easier to hear than "you never care."

THURSDAY, 4:50PM

A message from your manager asks whether you have a minute tomorrow, and your stomach drops. By the time you get home you have snapped at the cat, skipped dinner and replayed every mistake of the last month, although nobody has said anything bad at all.

Feelings sit underneath almost everything else, from how we talk and how we see each other to how we handle stress. This chapter looks first at how feelings work and then at what to do with them.

01

A feeling is a signal, not a verdict.

Feelings are fast messages about what matters to you. Fear warns that something might be dangerous, anger that something seems unfair or in your way, and sadness that you have lost something that mattered. A signal is worth listening to, though it can be wrong about the details, the way a smoke alarm can go off for burnt toast.

For example, You feel jealous when a friend makes a new close friend. The jealousy proves nothing about you, and nothing about whether your friend is leaving. What it does show is how much the friendship matters to you.

THINGS TO TELL YOURSELF

"This feeling is telling me something matters. What is it?" "Is this the fire, or the toast?"

TRY THIS.

Next time a strong feeling arrives, finish this sentence: "This feeling is trying to protect…"

02

Feelings start in the body.

Often your body reacts before your mind has a word for it, with a racing heart, a hot face, a heavy chest or a knot in the stomach, and your brain then tries to make sense of the signal. That is why being hungry, tired or in pain can feel so like being upset, because the mind is guessing at what a strong signal means.

A teenager comes home furious with his mum over very little. After a cheese sandwich and twenty minutes on the sofa, most of the fury has gone, and he admits he skipped lunch.

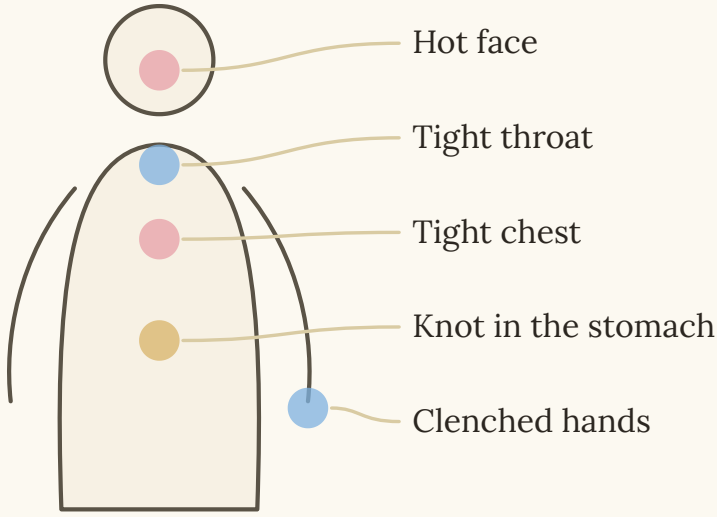
> THINGS TO TELL YOURSELF
> "Where is this in my body?" "Am I hungry, tired, cold or sore right now?"

THIS WEEK.

Three times today, pause and ask yourself what your body feels like right now, and leave it at noticing.

A feeling is a signal, not a verdict

It often shows up in the body before it has a word.



Feel it *in the body* → **Name it** *"I feel let down"* → **Choose** *what you do next*

It says: something here matters to me.
It doesn't say what to do.

Illustration. Everyone's body signals are a little different; these are common ones, not a medical map.

FIGURE 7 A feeling is a signal, not a verdict. It often shows up in the body first; naming it helps you choose what to do next.

FILLED-IN EXAMPLE 6

My weather today

Esme, 29, at 4:50pm, after "Got a minute tomorrow?" from her manager

Check today's weather

The sky

Clear: Calm and connected · *Gusty: Revved up* · Fogged in: Running on empty

Who you'll mostly be around today

A partner · Family · A co-parent · Roommates · *Coworkers* · Someone I care for · Friends · Mostly on my own

The pressure

Light · *Building* · Heavy

Ground conditions

Haven't eaten in a while · Thirsty · In pain or unwell · Been still all day · Too much noise or light · *Running on caffeine* · Screens since I woke up

Last night's sleep

Barely slept · Short night · *About enough* · Properly rested

People load

Barely any · *A normal amount* · A lot · Nonstop, no gaps

What's blowing in

Work · Money · Kids or caring · Health · Family · The house · *One conversation* · Something I can't name

What would actually help in the next hour?

Space · Food or water · Rest · To move · *To be heard* · *A plan* · Company · Quiet · Someone to take something off me

YOUR FORECAST

Gusty today
Revved up · Some room today

Talk window
wait about 20 minutes

It's gusty. You're revved up. That energy is useful for doing something physical, but it is poor weather for deciding anything about another person.

The ground underneath: you haven't eaten in a while and you're running on caffeine. That isn't a side note. It's likely a big part of why today feels the way it does, and it's easier to change than character is.

Blowing in: one conversation. Weather from one front tends to land on whoever is nearest, often someone who had nothing to do with it. Worth saying out loud before it does.

You said what would help is a plan and to be heard. Arrange that before anything else.

If you want to send someone a line: "I don't need it solved. I just need you to hear this for a few minutes first."

Esme ate something, then rang her sister to be heard. She didn't reply to the message until the morning.

Fill in your own: My weather today

SCAN TO OPEN

TOOL
My weather today
spreadloveandacceptance
.com/quick-checks

03

Naming a feeling helps you hold it.

Putting a feeling into words can turn its volume down a little. In brain-scan research by Lieberman and colleagues (2007), simply putting a name to a feeling ("I feel scared") turned down the brain's alarm response. A name gives a big, cloudy rush some edges, so that you can see it, talk about it and decide what to do.

For example, two housemates are tense all evening. Eventually one says, "I think I'm embarrassed about the noise complaint, and I've been acting cross," and the other, who had been wondering what she had done wrong, puts the kettle on.

> YOU COULD SAY
>
> "I think what I'm feeling is…" "I'm not sure what this is yet. Maybe worried?"

ONE SMALL STEP.

Once a day, name one feeling out loud or on paper. A guess like "something like sad" still counts.



PROFESSOR PUDDLES

If the words won't come, weather words often will. Pick "foggy" or "stormy" and start from there.

TOOL **My weather today** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/quick-checks

SCAN TO OPEN

TOOL
My weather today
spreadloveandacceptance
.com/quick-checks

04

More words, better tools.

“Bad” is a very blunt word. “Disappointed,” “left out,” “overwhelmed” and “ashamed” each point to something different, and each needs something different. A review by Kashdan, Barrett and McKnight (2015) found that people who can tell their feelings apart more finely tend to cope with them in healthier ways. You don’t need fancy words, and numbers, colours or body words work too.

A dad tells his partner that he feels bad about his mum, and they talk in circles for half an hour. Then he says, “Actually, I feel guilty that I haven’t visited, and scared she’s getting worse,” and they start looking at train times.

> WORDS YOU COULD USE
> “On a scale of one to ten, I’m about a six.” “It’s less angry and more… let down.” “It feels heavy, like a grey day.”

SOMETHING TO TRY.

When you notice “bad,” try for one more exact word. When you notice “fine,” try for one more honest one.

05

Feelings come in layers.

The feeling you show first isn’t always the first one you felt. Anger is often a cover for hurt or fear, because anger feels stronger and safer. We also have feelings about our feelings, such as being ashamed of being sad or scared of being angry, and that second layer can hurt more than the first.

For example, a grandmother is short with her daughter on the phone after the grandchildren’s visit is cancelled. Under the

shortness is hurt, and under the hurt is a quieter fear that she is no longer needed.

THOUGHTS YOU COULD TRY

"What might be under this one?" "It's okay to feel this. I don't also have to feel bad for feeling it."

TRY THIS.

Next time you feel angry, ask yourself gently whether there is hurt or worry underneath. You don't have to say it to anyone.

06

Feelings rise and pass like waves.

Most feelings, even big ones, rise, peak and settle if you don't keep feeding them. Moods are different. A mood is more like weather, a background feeling that lasts hours or days and colours everything, often without you noticing. A grey mood can make a small thing feel huge, and a good mood can make the same thing feel like nothing.

A woman living alone has a bad morning and decides her whole life is going nowhere. By evening, after a walk and a long call with her sister, the same life looks ordinary and fairly okay, with a dentist's appointment on Tuesday and a book she wants to finish.

THINGS TO TELL YOURSELF

"This is a wave. It will peak and pass." "Is this a feeling about now, or a mood colouring everything?"

THIS WEEK.

Leave big decisions until the wave has passed. Write the decision down and look at it again tomorrow.

07

Feelings spread between people.

We pick up each other's feelings from a tense voice, a sigh or a slammed door, often without noticing. That is part of how people bond, and it also means stress can move round a home or a team like a cold. You can care about someone's feeling without catching all of it.

For example, a team leader comes into a meeting rushed and anxious, and within ten minutes the whole team feels behind. The next week she stops at the door for two slow breaths before she goes in, and the meeting runs to time.

THINGS TO TELL YOURSELF

"Is this feeling mine, or did I pick it up?" "I can stay beside their storm without standing in the middle of it."

ONE SMALL STEP.

Notice who you tend to "catch" feelings from. Before your next talk with them, settle yourself for one minute first.



TIDBIT

Tidbit wants you to know: good moods are catching too! Tail wags definitely are. Want a small way to share one?

TOOL **Stay close: one small idea** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/bonding

SCAN TO OPEN

TOOL
Stay close: one small idea
spreadloveandacceptance.com/bonding

08

If you weren't brought up to talk about feelings.

Many people grew up in homes, generations or cultures where feelings were kept private, with sayings like "Don't make a fuss", "Big boys don't cry" and "We don't talk about that." This is common for men and for older people, and in some cultures it is a sign of respect and strength.

Keeping feelings private is no flaw, and it doesn't mean you don't feel. Many people who rarely put a feeling into words show it every day by doing, whether that is fixing the tap, driving someone to hospital or simply turning up. Caring by doing is real caring, and words can be added slowly, a few at a time.

A retired builder whose wife has died has never talked about his feelings. On the touchline at his grandson's football match, he says to his son, "I wasn't brought up to say this, but I miss her. Every morning." His son puts a hand on his shoulder, and they watch the second half together.

WAYS TO SAY IT

"I wasn't brought up to say this, but I miss her." "I'm not good with words for this. It's been a hard week." "I don't know what to call it. I just feel heavy." "I'm not one for talking, but I wanted you to know I'm proud of you."

SOMETHING TO TRY.

Pick one sentence above and say it once this week, to one person or just out loud on your own. A text counts, and so does writing it down.

09

Feeling it isn't the same as doing it.

A feeling usually comes with an urge to shout, run, hide, check, fix or text. You don't choose the feeling, but you have more choice over what you do with the urge. Pushing a feeling down tends to make it come back stronger, and acting on every urge can hurt people, so the middle path is to let the feeling be there and choose the action.

For example, a father feels a hot rush of anger when his son breaks a window with a football. He says, "I'm too cross to talk right now. Let's sort this out in ten minutes," and goes to fetch the dustpan.

WORDS TO TRY

"I'm feeling a lot right now. I'm going to take a minute before I answer." "I want to reply when I'm calmer."

TRY THIS.

Pick one urge you often act on too fast, like sending a sharp text, and make a rule to wait ten minutes first.

FRIDAY, 9:05AM

You notice the knot in your stomach again, and this time you name it. You are scared you are in trouble. So you ask your manager straight away whether today's chat is something you should worry about, and she looks surprised and says it is about the summer rota. You go back to your desk and eat the breakfast you skipped.

In everyday life

If you live on your own, nobody else is there to notice how you are, so a daily one-word check-in with yourself matters more (see On my own). With a partner, “What are you feeling?” can sound like a test, while “Do you want to tell me, or shall I just sit with you?” is easier to answer. Children learn feeling words from the adults around them, and saying “I’m frustrated, so I’m taking a breath” teaches more than any lesson. At work, a short “I’m a bit flat today, and I’m not upset with anyone” can stop a whole team guessing. If someone close to you shows care by doing, by clearing the drive or cooking on a bad day, you can thank them for it in words.

SCAN TO OPEN

ONLINE
On my own
spreadloveandacceptance
.com/on-my-own

Common mix-ups

- **"Some feelings are bad."** Some feelings are painful and some actions are harmful, but the feeling itself is information.
- **"If I feel it, it must be true."** Feeling stupid doesn't make you stupid. A feeling is a signal to check.
- **"I should be able to name it straight away."** Many people find feelings hard to name, and some find it very hard. Body words, numbers and colours all count.
- **"Their face tells me what they feel."** Faces are a poor guide, because people show the same feeling in different ways, and asking is kinder and more accurate than guessing.

If you want to help someone else with this

- **Ask before you name it for them.** "You're angry" can feel like a label, while "You seem upset. Am I reading that right?" leaves room for them to correct you.
- **Make the feeling make sense.** "Of course you're upset, that was a lot" helps more than advice, and you can make sense of a feeling without agreeing with every action.
- **Offer choices.** "Do you want ideas, or just someone to listen?" Many people only want the second.
- **Accept other ways of saying it.** A number, a text, a drawing or "I'm at a seven" is a real answer.
- **Settle yourself first.** If their sadness makes you anxious, calm down before you go to them, so they don't have to look after your feelings too.

YOU COULD SAY

"That sounds really hard." "Do you want to talk, or would company help more?" "You don't have to find the right word. A number is fine."

When to get more help

Everyone has hard days and big feelings. It may be time to talk to a doctor, a counsellor or another trained professional if:

- a low, numb, anxious or angry feeling stays most days for two weeks or more;
- feelings are stopping you from sleeping, eating, working or seeing people;
- you are using alcohol, drugs or other things to stop feeling;
- you feel you can't cope, or have thoughts of harming yourself. If that's happening now, contact your local emergency number or a crisis line straight away. You deserve help today.

If you feel afraid of someone you live with or are close to, that fear is an important signal. It is not something to "manage" on your own. Not safe at home? (spreadloveandacceptance.com/safety) lists free, private help.

This chapter is general education, not a diagnosis or therapy. It can't know your situation.

SCAN TO OPEN



ONLINE
Not safe at home?
spreadloveandacceptance
.com/safety

Workpapers, tools and reading on the website

Workpapers **pages you fill in, on your own or together**

- The Calm-Down Kit: a plan, made on a calm day, for heated moments.

SCAN TO OPEN



WORKPAPER WP-11 · free to print
The Calm-Down Kit
spreadloveandacceptance
.com/workpapers/fill/
wp-11

Tools **helpers you use on the website**

- My weather today: a short, private daily check of your mood and state.
- Upset right now?: steps for when a feeling is very big, very fast.

SCAN TO OPEN

TOOL
My weather today
spreadloveandacceptance
.com/quick-checks

TOOL
Cool-down corner:
Upset right now?
spreadloveandacceptance
.com/upset-right-now

WHAT TO REMEMBER

- ✓ **A feeling is a signal** that something matters to you. It doesn't tell you what to do about it.
- ✓ **Feelings start in the body.** A tight chest or a hot face often comes before the word for it.
- ✓ **Naming helps.** "I feel let down" is easier to hold than a big, nameless rush.
- ✓ **You can let a feeling be there** and still choose what you do next.

THIS CONNECTS TO

Chapter 2 · Your wiring, weather and words
Reading your own weather day to day — page 25

Book 4, Chapter 3 · Full tanks and different angles
Feelings when a stress tank is full — Share the Load, page 49

Book 2, Chapter 1 · Stress and the nervous system
What the body does under pressure — Heal and Steady, page 9

Book 2, Chapter 2 · Anger
One feeling up close — Heal and Steady, page 31

PUT IT TO USE

The Calm-Down Kit
Workpaper · free to print: A plan, made on a calm day, for heated moments
spreadloveandacceptance.com/workpapers/fill/wp-11

My weather today
A short, private daily check of your mood and state
spreadloveandacceptance.com/quick-checks

Go deeper (free online) The full chapter, with the research, more examples and more to try: spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/understanding-1-feelings-in-depth

5

BOOK 1 · CHAPTER 5

Self-worth, shame and self-compassion

Why your worth isn't a score you keep earning, how shame differs from guilt, and why being kind to yourself makes it easier to grow.

IN THIS CHAPTER

1. Your worth isn't a score
2. Guilt says "I did a bad thing." Shame says "I am bad."
3. Shame makes you want to hide
4. The inner critic is trying to protect you
5. Self-compassion isn't letting yourself off
6. Comparing yourself pulls your worth outside you
7. You can own a mistake without drowning in it
8. Worth is learned between people, and we can give it
9. In everyday life
10. Common mix-ups
11. If you want to help someone else with this
12. When to get more help
13. Tools and reading on this site
14. More for your situation

THURSDAY, 11:20PM

You sent the wrong file to the whole team. Someone noticed, fixed it and said there were no worries. Hours later you are still awake and replaying it, and the voice in your head has moved on from the file. It is telling you that you are useless, and that everyone knows it now.

This chapter looks at how self-worth and shame work and then at what you can do about them, whether you are on your own, at

home, with friends or at work. Nothing here is a diagnosis, so take what helps and leave the rest.

01

Your worth isn't a score.

Many of us carry a quiet scoreboard on which we are worth something only when we are useful, liked, slim, busy, top of the class or never a bother. Psychologists call these "conditions of worth", and the trouble with them is that any score can drop. If your worth rises and falls with each day's results, every bad day feels like a verdict on you. A retired teacher may feel lost for months after she stops working, even though nothing is wrong, because for forty years being needed was how she knew she mattered.

It can help to finish the line "I feel okay about myself when I…" three times. The endings you write are your scores, and for now it is enough to notice them. On a bad day, you might remind yourself that you matter on days when you achieve nothing at all.

02

Guilt says "I did a bad thing." Shame says "I am bad."

Guilt is about something you did, so it points towards fixing it by saying sorry or making it right. Shame is about who you are, which feels impossible to fix, and so it tends to make people hide, freeze, blame someone else or lash out. Research on the two feelings, such as June Tangney and Ronda Dearing's (2002), suggests guilt is more likely to lead to repair. When a teenager breaks his mum's favourite mug, guilt tells him to own up and offer to help pay for a new one. Shame tells him he ruins everything, and he wraps the pieces in newspaper and hides them at the bottom of the bin.

Next time you feel bad about something, ask whether it is about what you did or about who you are. If it has become about who

you are, try to turn it back into one thing you did, and then ask what would make that thing right.

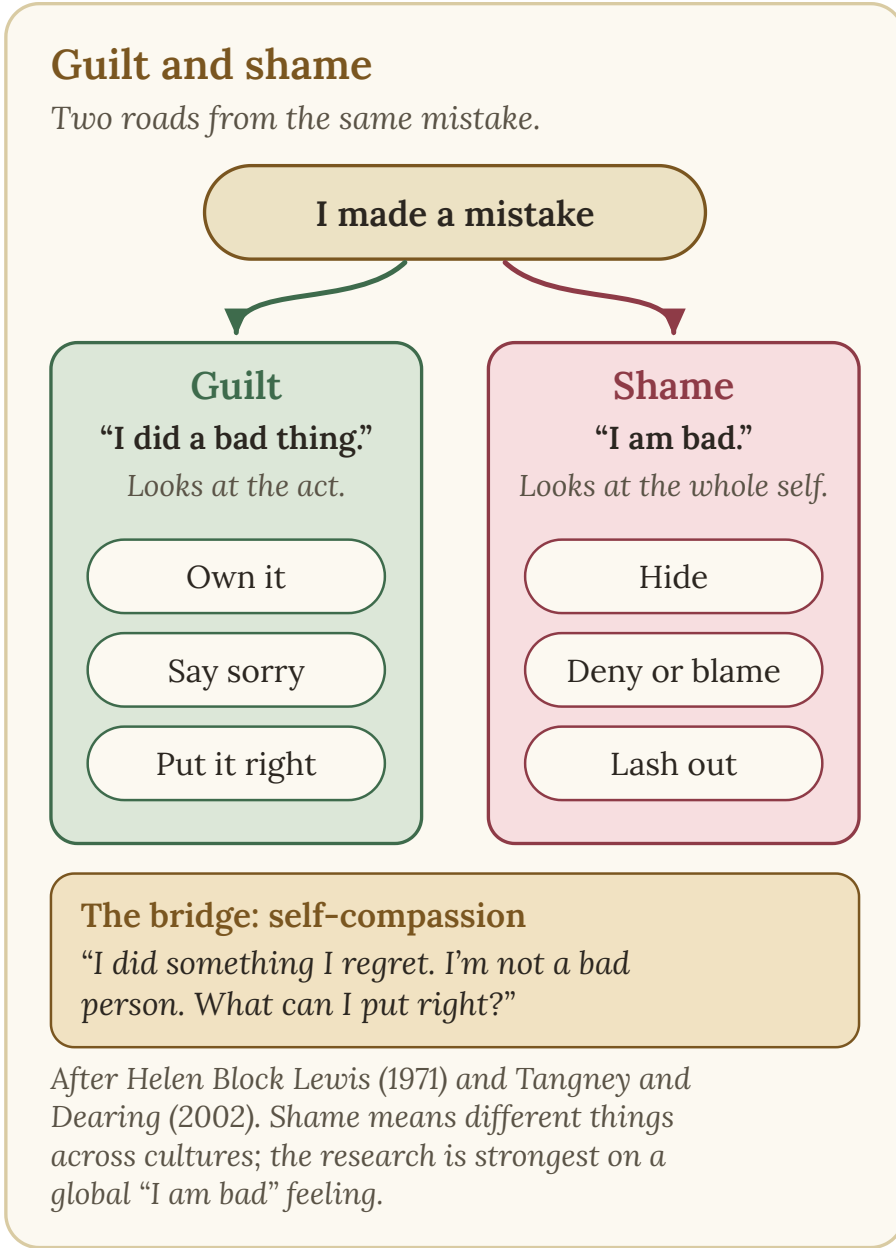


FIGURE 8 Guilt says "I did a bad thing." Shame says "I am bad." Guilt is easier to put right, and self-compassion helps you cross over.

03

Shame makes you want to hide.

Shame shows up in the body first, as a hot face, lowered eyes, a sinking stomach and the wish for the floor to swallow you. It can also come out sideways, as sudden anger or a cold, closed face, which is how a small comment can start a big fight. In a meeting a coworker asks, “Didn’t we already cover this?”, and his colleague snaps back at him. Later she realises the snap had nothing to do with the question, because what she felt was stupid in front of everyone.

Learning your own shame signs helps. Next time you suddenly want to disappear or to snap, you can name it quietly to yourself as shame, and sometimes say out loud, “I think I felt embarrassed just then, and it came out sharp. Can I try again?”

04

The inner critic is trying to protect you.

That harsh inner voice usually started as protection. If you criticise yourself first, perhaps nobody else can hurt you, and if you are hard on yourself, perhaps you will never fail again. It meant well. A voice that only threatens keeps your body on alert, though, and it is tiring to live with. A young dad calls himself an idiot every time he forgets something for the baby, the same word his own father used about him, so the voice he hears is an old one that he borrowed long ago.

Write down one thing your inner critic says often, and ask whether you would say it to a friend you love, and what you would say instead. Some people find it helps to answer the critic directly, with something like “Thanks for trying to protect me. I can take it from here.”

FILLED-IN EXAMPLE 7

Flip it

Hamish, 44, after a mistake at work

Flip it

What's on your mind?

I got the figures wrong in the client report and my manager had to fix it. I'm hopeless at this job.

What kind is it?

A complaint about someone · A worry · *Being hard on myself* · Anger

THE FLIP

What a good friend might say

"That sounds like a hard moment. One mistake is not the whole of you. You're not hopeless. You're a person having a hard day."

Kinder words for yourself

"I had a hard moment. I'm human. Next time I'll [one thing]."

One next step

[one small thing, like a short sorry, a reminder on your phone, or some rest]

Talking to yourself the way you'd talk to a friend is a simple form of self-compassion. Being harsh rarely makes the next try easier. This is a starting point. Change any words you like.

Hamish's own words, after changing the flip

I got two figures wrong and it was caught before the client saw it. I'm human. Next time I'll ask a colleague to check the numbers before it goes out.

His next step
Send my manager a two-line sorry and the checking plan, today, then go home on time.

The flip is a starting point: Hamish changed the words until they were true and sounded like him.

Fill in your own: Flip it

SCAN TO OPEN

TOOL
Chat analyzer: Help me write it (ask for a change)
spreadloveandacceptance.com/small-wins

05

Self-compassion isn't letting yourself off.

Self-compassion means treating yourself the way you would treat a good friend who is struggling. One well-known model has three parts, which are kindness in place of attack, remembering that everyone struggles, and noticing the pain without drowning in it. Studies, such as one by Juliana Breines and Serena Chen (2012), suggest that people who are kind to themselves after a failure are often *more* likely to try to improve. A woman who fails her driving test for the third time tells herself that this is hard, that lots of people need more goes, and that she will practise reversing round corners before the next one. Then she books another lesson.

If it feels okay, put a hand on your chest or arm and say three lines slowly to yourself once today. "This is a hard moment." "Other people feel this too." "What do I need right now?"



SUGARFOOT

Sugarfoot's tip: speak to yourself the way you'd speak to a friend having a hard day, slowly and kindly. Writing it down first can help.

TOOL **Write it through** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/write-it-through

SCAN TO OPEN

TOOL
Write it through
spreadloveandacceptance
.com/write-it-through

06

Comparing yourself pulls your worth outside you.

We all measure ourselves against others, because that is how people work out where they stand. Feeds full of other people's best moments make that measuring unfair, and self-esteem that depends on being better than others goes up and down a great deal. Two old friends meet for dinner, one with a new house and the other renting a room. The renter spends the evening quietly ranking herself and misses the fact that her friend is lonely and had wanted to talk.

When you notice a comparison today, try swapping it for a question about the other person, such as "How are you, really?" It also helps to remember that you are comparing your inside with their outside.

07

You can own a mistake without drowning in it.

Owning a mistake is easier when it doesn't mean you are worthless. A simple shape helps. Say what you did, say what it did to the other person, say what you will do now, and then stop, because beating yourself up proves nothing about how sorry you are. A housemate forgot to pay her share of the bill and the internet was cut off for the weekend. She tells the others, "I forgot to pay, and that left you without internet all weekend. I've paid it and set a reminder," and that is the end of it.

Think of one small thing you still feel bad about, write the three-part sentence, and decide whether to send it, say it or simply let it rest.



PROFESSOR PUDDLES

Owning a mistake can be short and plain: what happened, that it was yours, what you'll do. If it went wrong in a talk, Rewind the talk helps you find the words.

TOOL **Rewind the talk** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/carrier-wave-decoder

SCAN TO OPEN

TOOL
Rewind the talk
spreadloveandacceptance.com/carrier-wave-decoder

08

Worth is learned between people, and we can give it.

Children learn their worth from how they are treated, and adults go on learning it. How we talk to each other matters a great deal, because "you did a careless thing" leaves room to change and "you're so careless" closes the door. Praise for effort and for who someone is, as well as for results, helps people feel they matter on bad days too. A team lead begins each project review by asking what the team learned instead of who got it wrong, and within a few months people are raising problems in week two instead of week ten.

Today you could say one thing to someone that has nothing to do with their results, such as "I'm glad you're here, whatever happened today" or "I'm glad I know you."

YOUR PART, AND ONLY YOUR PART. You can't control how other people judge you, or what you were taught about your worth growing up. You can control how you speak to yourself now, whether you repair what you can, and where you spend your time. Give your energy to people who treat you as someone who matters. More in Chapter 2: who you are today (page 25)

FRIDAY, 9:15AM

You write one line to the team, saying sorry for the mix-up with yesterday's file and attaching the right one. When the old voice starts up, you answer it the way you would answer a friend. You made a mistake and you fixed it, which is what a decent colleague does. Nobody mentions the file again, and by lunchtime you have stopped thinking about it too.

In everyday life

Shame turns up in ordinary places. Between partners, “You forgot to call” can land as “You’re a terrible partner”, so the reply comes out as a defence instead of a sorry. A child told “You’re so naughty” hears something about who they are, while “That was a naughty thing to do” leaves them a way back. A friend who says yes to everything may be quietly burning out because saying no feels like risking being dropped. At work, someone may hide a small error for weeks because owning it feels like proof that they don’t belong there.

On your own: a kinder voice to keep

You don’t need anyone else to start this, only to notice how you talk to yourself and to practise one gentler sentence. Catch the critic’s favourite words, such as “always”, “useless”, “pathetic” and “should”, and swap one of them for a plain fact, so that “I’m hopeless” becomes “I was late twice this week.” On hard days, keep a short list of things you did well, or simply did, and let getting up count. You are allowed to be disappointed in what you did and still be on your own side.

Common mix-ups

- **"Self-compassion is self-pity."** Self-pity says "only me, poor me." Self-compassion says "this is hard, and other people go through it too," which connects you to others.
- **"If I'm kind to myself, I'll get lazy."** Research suggests the opposite is more common, because fear of your own attack makes people avoid trying and hide mistakes.
- **"Self-worth means thinking I'm great."** It means you matter even on the days you are not great.

If you want to help someone else with this

Talk about what happened, never about what kind of person they are. Arguing with someone's shame ("You're not useless!") can feel like being told they are wrong to feel it, so you might try "It sounds like you feel really low about it. I don't see you that way." Helping them find one small thing they can do gives the feeling somewhere to go. Kindness on ordinary days, when nothing has gone wrong, teaches worth best of all.

> YOU COULD SAY
>
> "That sounds like it's weighing on you. Want to work out one thing that would help?" "You don't have to earn being cared about."

When to get more help

Everyone feels shame and self-doubt sometimes. It's worth talking to a doctor, counsellor or therapist if harsh thoughts about yourself are there most days, if they stop you working, eating,

sleeping or seeing people, or if you feel you deserve to be hurt. Therapies such as compassion-focused therapy and cognitive behavioural therapy are built to help with exactly this.

If you are having thoughts of hurting yourself or not wanting to be here, please tell someone today. In the US and Canada, call or text 988. In the UK and Ireland, call Samaritans free on 116 123. In Australia, call Lifeline on 13 11 14. In New Zealand, call or text 1737. Anywhere else, findahelpline.com lists free helplines. If you are in danger right now, call your local emergency number.

If someone close to you keeps telling you you're worthless, stupid or lucky to have them, that isn't a self-esteem problem. It can be a way of controlling someone. Signs to look out for and Not safe at home? have free, private help.

SCAN TO OPEN



ONLINE
Signs to look out for
spreadloveandacceptance.com/safety



ONLINE
Not safe at home?
spreadloveandacceptance.com/safety

Tools and reading on the website

Tools helpers you use on the website

- Upset right now? (spreadloveandacceptance.com/upset-right-now) for a feeling that is too big to think through
- Ask Professor Puddles, the site's chat host, to help you find a kinder sentence

SCAN TO OPEN

TOOL
Cool-down corner:
Upset right now?
spreadloveandacceptance
.com/upset-right-now

TOOL
Ask Professor Puddles
spreadloveandacceptance
.com/ask

WHAT TO REMEMBER

- ✓ Your worth isn't a score.
- ✓ Shame makes you want to hide.
- ✓ Self-compassion isn't letting yourself off.
- ✓ Comparing yourself pulls your worth outside you.
- ✓ Worth is learned between people, and we can give it.

THIS CONNECTS TO

Chapter 1 · Where your lens came from
Old rules that taught you your worth page 9

Chapter 3 · Who you are becoming
Kindness when a goal slips page 45

Book 2, Chapter 5 · Healing after hurt
Guilt, apology and forgiveness Heal and Steady, page 87

Book 2, Chapter 3 · Worry, low mood and trauma
When the inner critic gets loud Heal and Steady, page 51

PUT IT TO USE

Upset right now?
For a feeling that is too big to think through
spreadloveandacceptance.com/upset-right-now

Ask Professor Puddles
The site's chat host, to help you find a kinder sentence
spreadloveandacceptance.com/ask

Go deeper (free online) The full chapter, with the research, more examples and more to try: spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/understanding-7-worth-in-depth

6

BOOK 1 · CHAPTER 6

Personality, temperament and change across life

What personality is, where temperament comes in, how people change across their lives, and how to live and work with people who are made differently from you, without putting anyone in a box.

IN THIS CHAPTER

1. Traits are dials, not boxes
2. Temperament is the starting point
3. Situations matter too
4. Introvert and extravert is about energy, not liking people
5. People change across life
6. You can change on purpose, a little at a time
7. Every trait has gifts and costs
8. Differences are about fit, not fault
9. In everyday life
10. Common mix-ups
11. If you want to help someone else with this
12. When to get more help
13. Tools and reading on this site
14. More for your situation

IN SHORT

- **Traits work like dials.** Everyone sits somewhere along each one, and most people are near the middle.
- **Temperament is a starting point.** Babies already differ in how active, cautious or easily upset they are, and what happens next matters too.
- **People keep changing.** On average people grow steadier and more organised as they get older, and you can change on purpose, slowly.

- **Most clashes between personalities are about fit**, and nobody has to be at fault.

WHY THE TOOLS WORK. Two tools in other chapters rest on what this one explains.

- **The "How to talk to me" card and the style quiz** (Chapter 2 (page 25)) describe how you lean on a few dials, which is more useful than knowing which box someone put you in.
- **One owner per job** (Book 4, Chapter 2 (page 27)) lets people with different temperaments share a home or a team without changing who they are, because the jobs are arranged around the differences.

SATURDAY, 3:00PM

It is your aunt's seventieth birthday, and you are standing quietly by the cake when she announces, loud enough for the whole room, that you were always the shy one. Everyone laughs, and you smile along while something stings. You are forty-two and you stand in front of thirty children every weekday morning, so are you still the shy one, and were you ever?

We all describe people by their personality, as laid-back, a worrier or the organised one, and descriptions like these can harden into boxes. This chapter looks at how personality actually works, what stays the same and what changes.

01

Traits are dials, not boxes.

Personality is your usual pattern of thinking, feeling and acting. Many psychologists describe it with five broad traits, often called the "Big Five". They are **openness** (curious about new ideas and experiences), **conscientiousness** (organised and careful), **extraversion** (drawn to people and busy places), **agreeableness** (warm and cooperative) and **emotional stability** (how steady your moods are).

The same five turned up in work such as McCrae and Costa (1987), whether people rated themselves or were rated by people who knew them. Each one works like a dial, and most people sit somewhere near the middle of most dials.

For example, two friends take an online quiz, and one is told she is an introvert while the other is told he is an extravert. When they look at their actual scores, they are only a few points apart, both close to the middle.

> THINGS TO TELL YOURSELF
> "I'm more of this than that, some of the time." "A label is only a summary."

TRY THIS.

For each of the five dials, mark where you think you sit from one to ten, and then ask yourself where a close friend would put you.

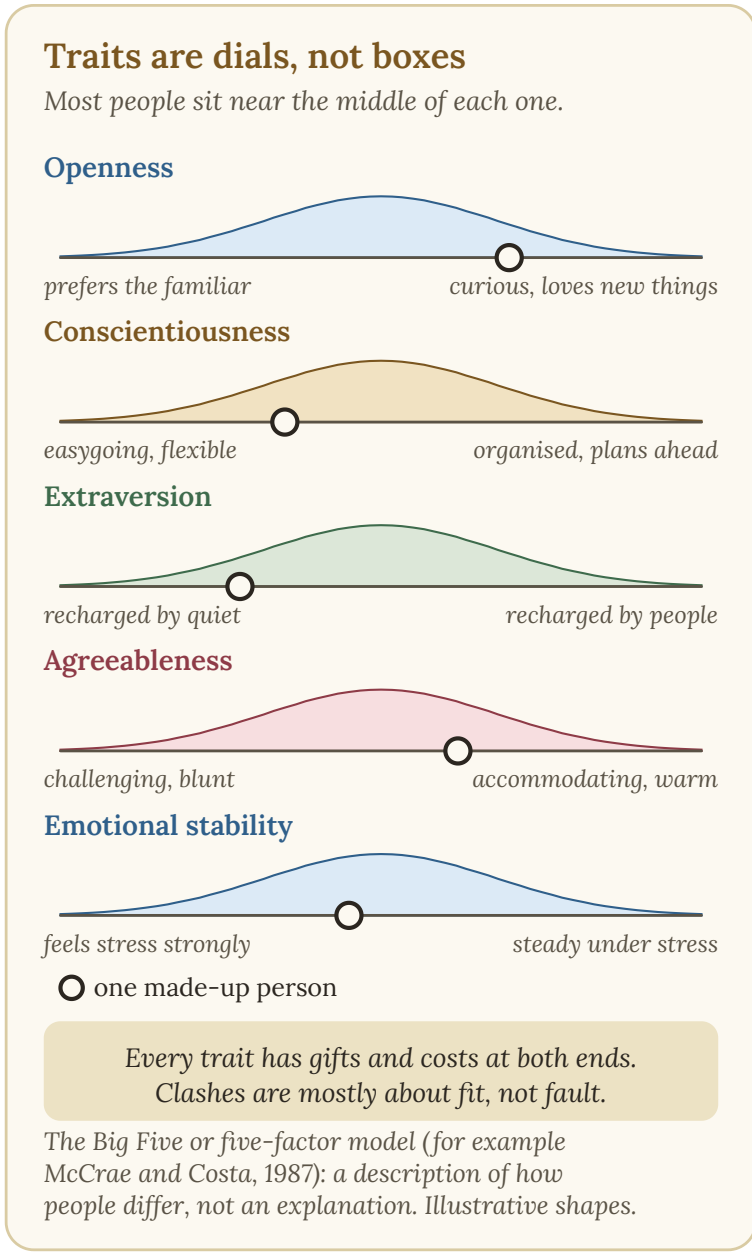


FIGURE 9 Traits are dials, not boxes: most people sit near the middle of each. Illustrative shapes.

02

Temperament is the starting point.

Temperament is the part of personality we can see from very early on. Some babies are very active and some calm, some settle easily into new routines while others take time, and some react strongly to noise or change. In their long-running study, Thomas and Chess (1977) described these early differences and the idea of "goodness of fit", meaning how well a child's temperament fits what the people and places around them expect.

A toddler who is slow to warm up cries at every new playgroup. Her mum stops pushing her to join in and lets her watch from her lap for ten minutes first, and by the third week she climbs down and joins the sand table on her own.

> YOU COULD SAY
> "You like to watch first. That's fine. Join in when you're ready." (to yourself) "I need time to warm up. That's how I'm made."

THIS WEEK.
Think about what you were like as a small child, from what your family say or what you remember, and notice what seems the same now and what seems different.

03

Situations matter too.

Personality describes a pattern. The same person can be loud with family and quiet at work, organised in their job and messy at home, patient with children and short with call centres. A trait tells you what someone tends to do across many situations, and much less about what they will do in this one.

For example, a manager decides that a new colleague is cold. At the team's charity football match, the same colleague turns out to

be chatty, funny and warm, and the manager starts to wonder how much the open-plan office was shaping what she saw.

THINGS TO TELL YOURSELF

"I've only seen them in one setting." "Where am I most myself, and where am I least?"

ONE SMALL STEP.

Before deciding what someone is "like," try to see them in one different setting, or ask them about one.

04

Introvert and extravert is about energy, not liking people.

People who are more introverted often enjoy people very much, but find that busy, noisy social time uses up energy and that they need quiet to recover. People who are more extraverted often feel energised by company and busy places. Most of us are a mix, sometimes called an ambivert, and each kind of person simply needs different things to feel at their best.

After a wedding, one partner wants to go on to the after-party and the other wants bed and silence. One goes for an hour, the other goes back to the hotel, and they meet for a late breakfast.

WORDS YOU COULD USE

"I loved tonight, and I'm out of social energy." "Shall we go together, and I'll head home at ten?"

SOMETHING TO TRY.

Notice whether company, quiet or a bit of both refills you after a busy week, and plan some of it for this weekend.



TIDBIT

Tidbit wants you to know: some of us recharge at the park with everyone, and some under a quiet blanket. Both are great! A quiz can show you your own style.

TOOL **How you connect: the 2-minute style quiz** ·
spreadloveandacceptance.com/wavelength

SCAN TO OPEN

TOOL
How you connect: the 2-minute style quiz
spreadloveandacceptance.com/wavelength

05

People change across life.

Personality is fairly stable, but it can move. A large review by Roberts, Walton and Viechtbauer (2006) found that, on average, people become more organised, more emotionally steady and more confident with others as they move through adult life, with much of the change between 20 and 40. A later review by Bleidorn and colleagues (2022) found that emotional steadiness kept growing right across the lifespan. Big life events, roles and relationships all play a part.

For example, a man who was a nervous, disorganised student becomes a calm, steady nurse in his forties, and his old school friends barely recognise him. When they ask, he says that life kept asking him to cope and he slowly learned how.

THOUGHTS YOU COULD TRY

"Who I was at fifteen isn't who I have to be now." "People I knew years ago may have changed too."

TRY THIS.

Write down one way you have changed in the last ten years, and what helped it happen.

06

You can change on purpose, a little at a time.

People who want to change a trait can, slowly, mostly by acting differently in small ways, again and again. In a study by Hudson and Fraley (2015), people who set goals to change one of their traits tended, over sixteen weeks, to change in the direction they wanted. A review by Roberts and colleagues (2017) found that therapy was often linked to lasting change too, especially towards more emotional steadiness.

A woman who wants to be less shy at work makes one small plan, to say one thing in each team meeting, and after two months speaking up has started to feel ordinary.

THINGS TO TELL YOURSELF

"I don't have to become a different person. I can practise one different thing."

THIS WEEK.

Pick one small action that fits who you would like to be more of, such as replying to messages the same day or saying hello first, and do it three times this week. Book 2, Chapter 6 (page 105) has more on habits.

07

Every trait has gifts and costs.

No personality is the good one. Each trait helps in some places and gets in the way in others. Very agreeable people are kind and easy to be with, and may find it hard to say no. Very conscientious people are reliable, and may struggle to rest. People high in openness love new things, and may get bored with routine. Knowing your mix helps you use the gifts and plan for the costs.

For example, a highly organised woman is often irritated by her relaxed housemate. Then the boiler breaks on a freezing night, and he is the one who stays calm and finds a plumber at ten o'clock.

THINGS TO TELL YOURSELF

"What is the gift in this trait, and what is the cost?" "What they do that annoys me might be the flip side of something I value."

ONE SMALL STEP.

Pick one trait of yours that people sometimes complain about. Write down one time it helped.



PROFESSOR PUDDLES

Every trait has gifts and costs. Writing down what helps you on a one-page card turns a "flaw" into useful information.

TOOL **How you connect: how to talk to me** ·
spreadloveandacceptance.com/wiring-card

SCAN TO OPEN



TOOL
How you connect: how to talk to me
spreadloveandacceptance.com/wiring-card

08

Differences are about fit, not fault.

When two people with different personalities share a home, a family or a job, friction is normal. A tidy person and a relaxed one, a planner and someone spontaneous, a talker and someone who needs quiet can each be right in their own way, and what helps is naming the difference and agreeing how to live with it. Personality is also different from neurodivergence and from mental health conditions, and if something feels bigger than personality, Chapter 7 (page 111) may help.

A couple argue about every holiday, because one wants every hour planned and the other wants to wander. This year they plan the mornings and leave the afternoons free, and they still argue about the mornings.

> WAYS TO SAY IT
> “I think we’re just made differently here. What would work for both of us?” “I’m a planner and you’re not. Can we plan half and leave half?”

SOMETHING TO TRY.

Think of one person you clash with and name the difference without blame, as in "I like ___ and they like ___." Then think of one small arrangement that would suit you both.

FILLED-IN EXAMPLE 8

How you connect: the style quiz

Mo, before moving in with his friend Callum

The style quiz: just my Wave Code

Twelve quick either/or taps, about two minutes.

Your first name (optional)

Mo

Someone asks you a big question. You…

Answer right away and figure it out as I talk

Need a moment, or a day, to think first

A sudden change of plans feels…

Fine, maybe even fun Jarring. I need a heads-up or a transition

Starting something new, you want…

The why and the big vision The first concrete step

When something bothers you, you usually…

Say it plainly so we can fix it *Hint at it, or wait for the right moment*

Someone says "I'm fine." You…

Believe them. Fine means fine *Check their tone to see if they really are*

…and seven more like these.

MO'S FOUR LEANINGS (HIS WAVE CODE: S F N A)

What each letter means
Pace: leans Slow Simmer (S, not Quick Spark) · Lens: leans Forest (F, not Trees) · Sending: leans Nuanced (N, not Direct) · Receiving: strongly Attuned (A, not Explicit)

The nickname the tool gives it: the Willow
Reflective and soft-spoken. Feels the undercurrents of every room.

Watch for
agreeing in the moment just to fill the silence; your real needs getting lost in the cushioning.

Mo's style-quiz statement: "About how I'm wired: I think first and talk second, I tend to hint rather than say it straight, I see the big picture first, and I like to take my time."

A Wave Code is shorthand for four preferences, each a lean along a dial, not a type or a box. "Leans" means near the middle. Answers can change with the day, the setting and the person you're with.

Fill in your own: How you connect

SCAN TO OPEN

TOOL
How you connect: the 2-minute style quiz
spreadloveandacceptance.com/wavelength

YOUR PART, AND ONLY YOUR PART. You can get to know your own mix, look after what you need, and practise one small change if you want to. You can't change someone else's personality, and you don't have to change yours to be loved. If you're always the one bending to fit, it's fair to say so. Know your own wiring

SATURDAY, 5:30PM

As people start to leave, you think about sitting down next to your aunt and telling her about the thirty children. In the end you help clear the plates and say nothing. On the drive home you are still turning it over, half annoyed with her and half with yourself, and you wonder whether she will say it again at Christmas, and what you would like to say back if she does.

SCAN TO OPEN

ONLINE
Know your own wiring
spreadloveandacceptance.com/know-yourself

In everyday life

On your own

Knowing your own mix helps you plan a life that suits you, with the right amount of company, quiet, routine and novelty. "I'm just not a people person" might be true, or it might be an old label worth testing. With a partner, a shared plan such as one of you handling

the bills and the other the holidays often works better than trying to change each other. A quiet friend who doesn't text much may still care a great deal, so it is worth asking what kind of contact suits them. A child's temperament says nothing about good or bad parenting, and adjusting to fit them is a skill. Family roles like "the clever one" or "the difficult one" can stick long after they stop fitting, and you are allowed to grow out of them.

Common mix-ups

- **"You're either an introvert or an extravert."** Most people are somewhere in the middle, and it can shift with setting and mood.
- **"Personality is set by adulthood."** It keeps changing, slowly, across the whole of life.
- **"Online type quizzes tell you who you are."** Many popular quizzes sort people into a handful of types, while real people are spread along each dial. Quizzes are good for fun and conversation, and that includes the website's own Wave Code, which shows four leanings on four dials.
- **"They're just difficult."** "Difficult" often means "different from me", and it can also hide stress, illness or a need nobody has asked about.
- **"Changing would mean being fake."** Practising something new feels unnatural at first and becomes part of you over time.

If you want to help someone else with this

- **Drop the old labels.** Notice if you still describe someone the way they were years ago, and look for who they are now.

- **Ask instead of guessing.** "What helps you recharge?" or "How do you like to plan things?" tells you more than any guess from their personality.
- **Notice growth out loud.** "You handled that so calmly" can help someone see a change they hadn't noticed.
- **Describe the action.** "You're so uptight" or "You're just lazy" closes doors, while a description of what happened leaves them open.

> WORDS TO TRY
> "I used to think of you as the shy one. I don't think that fits any more." "What do you need to be at your best this week?"

When to get more help

Personality differences are normal and don't need fixing. It may be worth talking to a doctor, counsellor or psychologist if:

- a pattern in how you feel, think or relate to people keeps causing you or others real distress, across many parts of life;
- you feel very unsure who you are, or your moods swing so much it's hard to cope;
- worry, low mood or fear of people is stopping you from living the life you want.

Please don't diagnose yourself or anyone else with a "personality disorder" from what you read online. Those are clinical terms that only a qualified professional can use, after a proper assessment.

A personality trait never excuses controlling, frightening or hurtful behaviour. If you're afraid of someone close to you, Not safe at home? (spreadloveandacceptance.com/safety) lists free, private help.

This chapter is general education, not a diagnosis or therapy.

SCAN TO OPEN



ONLINE
Not safe at home?
spreadloveandacceptance
.com/safety

Tools and reading on the website

Tools helpers you use on the website

- How you connect: four quick dials for how you think, talk and listen. Its four-letter Wave Code is shorthand for four preferences, not a type.
- Communication style quiz.

SCAN TO OPEN



TOOL
How you connect: the 2-minute style quiz
spreadloveandacceptance
.com/wavelength



ONLINE
Communication style quiz
spreadloveandacceptance
.com/communication-
style-quiz

THIS CONNECTS TO

Chapter 2 · Your wiring, weather and words
Your wiring today page 25

Chapter 1 · Where your lens came from
Temperament and how you grew up page 9

Chapter 7 · Minds that work differently
Minds that work differently page 111

Book 2, Chapter 6 · Habits and change
How change really happens Heal and Steady, page 105

PUT IT TO USE

How you connect
Four quick dials for how you think, talk and listen. Its four-letter Wave Code is shorthand for four preferences, not a type
spreadloveandacceptance.com/wavelength

Communication style quiz
spreadloveandacceptance.com/communication-style-quiz

Go deeper (free online) The full chapter, with the research, more examples and more to try: spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/understanding-14-personality-in-depth

7

BOOK 1 · CHAPTER 7

Minds that work differently

How autistic, ADHD, sensory and learning differences work, why none of them is a character flaw, and how people with different minds can meet in the middle.

IN THIS CHAPTER

1. Brains vary, like bodies do
2. Autism is a different way of sensing and connecting
3. ADHD is about steering attention, not lacking it
4. Everyone has a sensory profile
5. Learning differences aren't about intelligence
6. Masking costs energy
7. Autistic burnout is more than being tired
8. Meltdowns and shutdowns aren't choices
9. Stimming helps, so let it be
10. Deep focus makes switching hard
11. Deep interests are a source of joy and rest
12. Meet in the middle, out loud
13. Labels are tools, and they belong to the person
14. Finding out later in life
15. Getting things started and finished is a skill of its own
16. When demands feel like a threat
17. Not recognising faces isn't rudeness
18. Not speaking isn't the same as having nothing to say
19. Telling friends and dates is your choice
20. Finding your people
21. In everyday life
22. Common mix-ups
23. If you want to help someone else with this
24. When to get more help
25. Tools and reading on this site
26. More for your situation

IN SHORT

- **Brains vary, like bodies do.** A different mind is not a broken one, though differences can still be disabling in a world built for one kind of mind.

- **Nobody chooses overload.** Meltdowns, shutdowns and burnout are what happens when a nervous system has had too much.
- **Less masking, room to stim, time for deep interests and real rest** help a great deal.
- **Meet in the middle, out loud.** Ask what helps, say what helps you, and use the words each person chooses.

WHY THE TOOLS WORK. Two tools in other chapters rest on what this one explains.

- **The "How to talk to me" card** (Chapter 2 (page 25)) works because different minds need different input, and saying things plainly is an adjustment that helps almost everyone.
- **One owner per job and the written job list** (Book 4, Chapter 2 (page 27)) move memory out of anyone's head and onto paper, which helps ADHD and autistic minds most and everyone a little.

MONDAY, 8:15AM

You ask him for the third time to just put his shoes on. Your son is lying on the hall floor with his hands over his ears, because the new socks feel wrong, and you are already late. To him the seam across his toes feels like sandpaper, and the alarm clock from the bedroom is still ringing in his head.

This chapter is for neurodivergent people, diagnosed or not, and for the people who live, work and learn with them. It explains how these minds work and then what helps. It can't diagnose anyone, and only you get to choose the labels you use for yourself.

01

Brains vary, like bodies do.

People's brains differ in how they take in the world, focus, move, read, remember and connect with others. "Neurodiversity" is the idea that this variety is natural. "Neurodivergent" describes people whose minds work differently from what is treated as typical. A different mind is not a broken one, and at the same time differences can be disabling, especially when the world is built for one kind of mind.

For example, a man who struggled all through school finds out at forty that he is dyslexic. Mostly he feels relief, because for thirty years he had half believed the teachers who called him lazy.

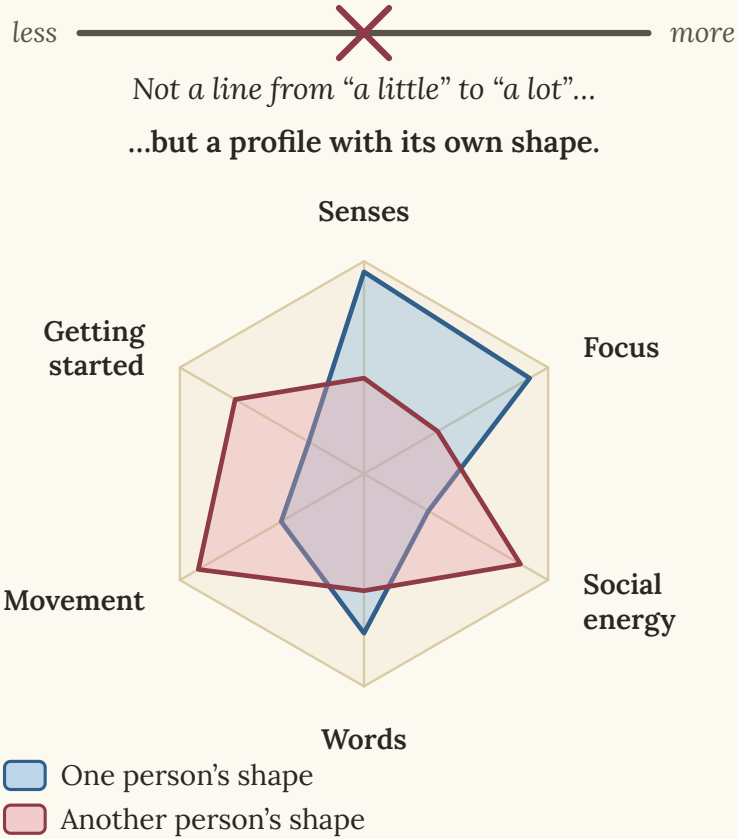
> THOUGHTS YOU COULD TRY
>
> "Maybe this isn't a flaw. Maybe it's a difference that needs a different setup."

TRY THIS.

Think of one thing that is hard for you and easy for others, and ask whether the difference is effort or a different kind of brain.

Brains vary, like bodies do

Different, not broken.



Strong in some places, stretched in others.
Ask what helps, and say what helps you.

Illustration, not a test. "Spiky profile" is a common way to describe uneven strengths and needs.

FIGURE 10 Brains vary, like bodies do. A mind has a profile with its own shape, not a place on a line from "a little" to "a lot". Different, not broken.

02

Autism is a different way of sensing and connecting.

Autistic people often communicate more directly and literally, have deep and focused interests, feel senses more (or less) intensely, and find predictability calming. Autism doesn't run along a single line from "mild" to "severe", because each autistic person has their own mix of strengths and needs, which can change from day to day. Misunderstandings between autistic and non-autistic people usually run both ways.

An autistic coworker mentions that her colleague's slides have three typos. She means it as help, and he hears criticism, because they are using different rules for what kindness sounds like.

YOU COULD SAY

"I like it when people say exactly what they mean. You can be direct with me." "Do you want my honest view, or just support right now?"

THIS WEEK.

In one conversation today, say exactly what you mean without hints, and notice whether it makes things easier.

03

ADHD is about steering attention, not lacking it.

People with ADHD often have plenty of attention but find it hard to point it where they choose. Boring tasks can feel impossible while interesting ones swallow hours, time can feel slippery, divided into "now" and "not now", and feelings can come fast and big. It is a real difference in how the brain manages itself, and it has nothing to do with effort or care.

For example, a woman with ADHD forgets her friend's birthday and then spends six hours making her a handmade card with pressed

flowers, because the forgetting and the focus come from the same brain.

WORDS YOU COULD USE

"I care about this. My brain drops things. A reminder really helps, and it doesn't annoy me."

ONE SMALL STEP.

Move one thing you keep forgetting out of your head and into the world, with an alarm, a note on the door or a basket by the exit.

04

Everyone has a sensory profile.

We all take in sound, light, touch, smell, taste, movement and signals from inside the body. Some people feel these strongly and get overloaded by noise or scratchy clothes. Others need more input, such as movement, strong flavours or pressure. Overload is a body at its limit, which is very different from being fussy.

Two housemates argue about the kitchen radio, because one finds silence eerie and the other finds the radio painful. They settle on the radio in the mornings and headphones in the evenings.

WAYS TO SAY IT

"The noise in here is too much for me right now. Can we move somewhere quieter?"

SOMETHING TO TRY.

Notice one sound, light or texture that drains you and one that calms you, and make one small change today.

PROFESSOR PUDDLES

Knowing your own sensory profile is useful information, not a complaint. A one-page card lets you share what helps, in your own words.

TOOL **How you connect: how to talk to me** ·
spreadloveandacceptance.com/wiring-card

SCAN TO OPEN

TOOL
How you connect: how to talk to me
spreadloveandacceptance.com/wiring-card

05

Learning differences aren't about intelligence.

Dyslexia (reading and spelling), dyscalculia (numbers), dyspraxia (coordination and planning movement) and language disorders are specific differences, and none of them measures how clever someone is. Many people have a "spiky" profile, very strong in some areas and struggling in others, and the right tools, like audiobooks, spoken notes or extra time, can level the ground.

For example, a teenager with dyspraxia is called clumsy on the football pitch, and in the same term he writes and directs the school play.

WORDS TO TRY

"I learn better when I can listen than when I read. Could you send a voice note instead?"

TRY THIS.

Ask someone you live or work with what the easiest way is for them to take in information, and then use it.

06

Masking costs energy.

Many neurodivergent people learn to hide their differences by copying others, forcing eye contact, holding back movements and rehearsing small talk. This is called masking. It can help someone get through a day, but it uses a lot of energy, and over years it can lead to exhaustion, anxiety and burnout.

A student seems fine all day at college, then comes home and can't speak for an hour while she recovers from a day of performing.

YOU COULD SAY

"I need some quiet time after work. It's how I recharge, and I'm not upset with you."

THIS WEEK.

Notice one place where you can drop the mask a little, and one person you can be fully yourself with. Spend a bit more time there.

07

Autistic burnout is more than being tired.

Autistic burnout is a deep, long-lasting exhaustion. Working with autistic adults, Raymaker and colleagues (2020) described it as long-term exhaustion, loss of skills (like speech, planning or self-care) and lower tolerance of noise, light and other input. It comes from long stress without enough support, and often lasts months. Rest, fewer demands and less masking help. Pushing harder usually makes it worse.

WORDS YOU COULD USE

"I'm in burnout. What I need for a while is fewer demands." "I can't do phone calls at the moment. Can we message instead?"

ONE SMALL STEP.

If you think you might be in burnout, list three demands you could drop, delay or share for a month. If it goes on, or you feel hopeless, talk to a doctor.

08

Meltdowns and shutdowns aren't choices.

A **meltdown** is an involuntary loss of control when overwhelm gets too much, which can look like crying, shouting, running off or lashing out. A **shutdown** is the quiet version, going still, losing speech and not being able to respond. Neither is a tantrum. In interviews by Phung and colleagues (2021), autistic young people described meltdowns and shutdowns as separate experiences, both linked to overload. What helps is less of everything, so less noise, fewer words and fewer questions, with more space and safety. Talking can wait.

WAYS TO SAY IT

(to someone else) "You're safe. I'm right here. No need to talk."
(for yourself) "I'm overloaded. I need quiet for twenty minutes."

SOMETHING TO TRY.

On a calm day, agree a simple signal for "I'm overloaded" and a quiet place to go.

09

Stimming helps, so let it be.

Stimming means repeated movements or sounds, like rocking, flapping, tapping, humming, pacing or fiddling with something. Most people stim a little (think of a jiggling foot). For many autistic people it matters a lot. In interviews by Kapp and colleagues (2019), autistic adults described stimming as a way to cope with overwhelming emotions and sensations, and objected to efforts to stop harmless stimming. If it isn't hurting anyone, it doesn't need stopping.

> WORDS TO TRY
> "Rocking helps me think. It doesn't mean anything's wrong."
> "You don't need to stop. It's fine with me."

TRY THIS.

Notice what your own hands or body do when you're stressed, focused or happy. That's your stim.

10

Deep focus makes switching hard.

Some minds, often autistic and ADHD ones, focus deeply on one thing at a time. That focus can be a gift, bringing real expertise, flow and joy. It also makes switching tasks hard, so being interrupted can feel like being pulled out of water, and warnings before a change help a lot.

For example, a dad calls his daughter to dinner three times and gets more frustrated each time. The next evening he gives her a ten-minute warning and then a five-minute one, and she comes to the table still talking about the castle she has been building.

YOU COULD SAY

"Dinner is in ten minutes. I'll come and get you at five to." "Can you give me a warning before we switch?"

THIS WEEK.

Before you interrupt someone who is focused, give them a heads-up and a time, and see whether it goes more smoothly.

11

Deep interests are a source of joy and rest.

Many autistic people have deep, intense interests, often called special interests. The theory of monotropism (Murray, Lesser and Lawson, 2005) describes autistic attention as pulled strongly into a few things at a time. In a survey of autistic adults by Grove and colleagues (2018), people who were more motivated by and engaged with their special interests reported higher wellbeing, though very intense engagement went with lower wellbeing.

WORDS YOU COULD USE

"Can I tell you about this for five minutes? It's how I unwind." "Tell me more. What's the best bit?"

ONE SMALL STEP.

Ask someone about their favourite subject, and let them talk for five minutes without steering.



TIDBIT

Tidbit wants you to know: this site can change to fit your mind too, with bigger text, calmer pages and fewer surprises. Ooh, try it!

TOOL **Read your way** · spreadloveandacceptance.com/how-you-take-things-in

SCAN TO OPEN



TOOL
Read your way
spreadloveandacceptance
.com/how-you-take-
things-in

12

Meet in the middle, out loud.

When two kinds of mind live or work together, neither should have to do all the adjusting. Clear, explicit words help everyone, so say what you mean, give times, write things down and ask what helps. Changes made for one person, like quiet spaces, written agendas or flexible hours, often help many others too.

A team starts sending meeting agendas a day early for one autistic colleague, and within a month most of the team are saying the meetings have become shorter.

> WAYS TO SAY IT
> "What would make this easier for you?" "Here's what helps me. What helps you?"

SOMETHING TO TRY.
Swap one "how I work best" fact with someone today, telling them one thing that helps you and asking for one that helps them.

FILLED-IN EXAMPLE 9

“How to talk to me” card, for work

Tom, autistic, for his new manager

Your card

Who it’s for

A partner · Family · A friend · *Work (a manager or coworker)*

Name on the card, optional

Tom

WIRING CARD · NOT A DIAGNOSIS

How I receive things best
A written list.

I take words
Literally.

Give me time to answer
Write it down so I can answer later.

Please avoid
A hard topic with no warning. Correcting me in public.

A request lands best as
"Could you ___ by ___?"

Also good to know about me
If I go quiet, I'm processing, not upset. Tell me the plan, and tell me if it changes. Noise, light or touch can wear me out.

Sensory needs
Short breaks in long talks.

Sent with one line: "Here's a short card about how I work best. It's not a request for anything big; it just helps us avoid crossed wires."

Sharing a card is always the person's own choice.

Fill in your own: "How to talk to me" card

SCAN TO OPEN

TOOL
How you connect: how to talk to me
spreadloveandacceptance.com/wiring-card

13

Labels are tools, and they belong to the person.

A diagnosis can bring understanding, support and community. Some people find their way to a label through self-discovery first. Many autistic adults prefer “autistic person”; others prefer “person with autism.” The kindest rule is to ask and to use the words the person chooses, and never to try to diagnose someone else, especially in an argument.

For example, during a row, a man tells his partner, “You’re so autistic.” It lands as an insult and ends the conversation. The next morning he apologises and asks what his partner actually needs from him.

> WORDS TO TRY
> “How do you like to describe yourself?” “I’m wondering if I might be neurodivergent. I’d like to find out more.”

TRY THIS.
If you have wondered about yourself, write down what you have noticed and decide one small next step, such as reading, talking to someone or asking a doctor.

14

Finding out later in life.

More and more adults are finding out they are autistic, or have ADHD, in their thirties, fifties or seventies. Many were missed as children, especially women. In interviews by Leedham and colleagues (2020), women diagnosed at forty or older described how exhausting it had been to go so long without an explanation, and how much the diagnosis changed how they understood their lives. Relief, grief and joy can all come together.

YOU COULD SAY

"I've just found out I'm autistic. I'm still working out what it means." "That explains so much about my life."

THIS WEEK.

If you've found out later in life, look for one autistic-led group, book or online space, and give yourself time to make sense of it.

15

Getting things started and finished is a skill of its own.

Planning, starting, switching, remembering what you were doing and keeping track of time are called **executive function**. Many autistic and ADHD people find some of these harder, on some days more than others. A review of 235 studies by Demetriou and colleagues (2018) found differences in executive function in autism on average, with a lot of variation between people. The brain's self-management system is working differently, and laziness has nothing to do with it, so it often helps to move the managing out of your head and into the world.

A woman can write a brilliant report but can't get herself to post a parcel. Once the parcel sits by the front door with a sticky note and a phone alarm, it goes on Tuesday.

WORDS YOU COULD USE

"Could you send me that as a list? Spoken steps fall out of my head." "I'm not ignoring it. Starting is the hard bit for me."

ONE SMALL STEP.

Pick one task that keeps not happening and make the first step tiny and visible, with a note, an alarm or the thing left where you will trip over it. See routines that help and Wired differently.

SCAN TO OPEN

ONLINE
routines that help
spreadloveandacceptance
.com/adhd-kids

ONLINE
Wired differently
spreadloveandacceptance
.com/wired-differently

16

When demands feel like a threat.

Some people, often autistic, feel strong anxiety when asked or expected to do things, even things they want to do. Avoiding the demand can look like refusing, joking, distracting or a meltdown. The profile was first described as "pathological demand avoidance," or PDA, by Newson and colleagues (2003).

It is not in the main diagnostic manuals, and researchers disagree about it. A review by Kildahl and colleagues (2021) found the evidence limited and mostly based on parent reports. Many people who identify with it prefer the phrase "persistent drive for autonomy." Whatever it is called, what helps tends to be the same, which is less pressure, more choice and requests that feel like invitations.

For example, a boy who refuses "Put your coat on now" happily puts it on when his dad says, "It's cold out. Coat or jumper, your choice."

WAYS TO SAY IT

"I wonder if we could…" "No rush. Which would you rather?" (for yourself) "Being told makes it harder. Can I choose when?"

SOMETHING TO TRY.

Turn one daily instruction into a choice or an invitation this week, and see what changes.

17

Not recognising faces isn't rudeness.

Prosopagnosia, or face blindness, means finding it hard to recognise people's faces, sometimes even close friends out of context. It can be something you're born with, and it often runs in families (NHS). Many autistic people also find remembering faces harder, as a review by Weigelt and colleagues (2012) found. People who don't recognise you may be relying on voices, hair, clothes or where they usually see you.

A man walks past his neighbour in the supermarket without a word, and she feels snubbed. When he explains later that he didn't recognise her without her dog, she starts saying hello first, with her name.

WORDS TO TRY

"I'm bad with faces, so please say who you are when you say hi." (to someone else) "Hi, it's Jo from next door."

TRY THIS.

If faces are hard for you, tell one or two people you see often. If not, try saying your name when you greet someone out of context.

18

Not speaking isn't the same as having nothing to say.

Some autistic people speak rarely, sometimes, or not at all, and some lose speech when stressed. Many communicate through **AAC** (augmentative and alternative communication), which can mean typing, letter boards, picture cards, apps or sign. Using AAC doesn't stop speech developing, and a review by Millar, Light and Schlosser (2006) found it did not hold speech back, and may help it. The safest starting point is to presume competence, which means assuming the person understands and has something to say, and giving them the time and tools to say it.

For example, at a family meal, a non-speaking teenager types on her tablet. Her uncle used to talk about her in front of her, and now he waits, reads her reply and answers her directly.

> YOU COULD SAY
>
> "Take your time. I'll wait." "Would you rather type or point?" (for yourself) "I can't talk right now. I can type."

THIS WEEK.

Talk to the person directly, and wait longer than feels natural for an answer.

19

Telling friends and dates is your choice.

Whether to tell someone you're autistic or ADHD, and when, is up to you. Telling can bring understanding. In a study by Sasson and Morrison (2019), people formed better first impressions of autistic adults when they knew they were autistic, especially if they knew more about autism.

But people don't always respond well, and interviews by Au-Yeung and colleagues (2025) describe autistic adults weighing hope for

support against fear of not being believed. Many people share a little at a time, starting with what helps before any label.

On a second date, a woman says, “I’m autistic, so I’m pretty direct, and I’d rather walk than sit in a loud bar.” Her date admits that he hates loud bars too, and they walk along the canal instead.

WORDS YOU COULD USE

“I’m autistic. For me that means…” “I won’t always pick up hints, so please just tell me.” (if someone shares with you) “Thanks for telling me. What helps?”

ONE SMALL STEP.

Write one sentence about what helps you, without a label, and practise it. You can add the label later if and when you want to.

20

Finding your people.

Many autistic people describe finding other autistic people as a turning point, because at last they don’t have to translate, explain or mask. Research backs this up. Cooper, Smith and Russell (2017) found that autistic people who felt more connected to other autistic people had higher self-esteem, and through that, less anxiety and depression. Being autistic can be an identity and a community as well as a diagnosis.

For example, after a late diagnosis, a man joins an online group for autistic adults who love old maps, and for the first time in years a long conversation leaves him with energy to spare.

THINGS TO TELL YOURSELF

“There are people who work like me.” “I can belong somewhere without masking.”

SOMETHING TO TRY.

Look for one autistic-led group, book, podcast or online space about something you love.

YOUR PART, AND ONLY YOUR PART. You can't change how your brain, or anyone else's, is wired. You can learn how yours works, say what helps, and ask others what helps them. Meeting in the middle means both people move a little. If you're always the one adjusting, it's fair to say so. More in Chapter 2: who you are today (page 25)

MONDAY, 8:30AM

You stop asking and sit on the hall floor next to him. "Socks feel wrong?" He nods. You switch off the alarm clock still beeping in the bedroom and fetch the old seamless pair, and two minutes later his shoes are on. You are ten minutes late, nobody has shouted, and that evening you order three more pairs of seamless socks and let him choose the colours.

In everyday life

On your own

Knowing how your mind works helps you build a life that fits it and spot burnout early (see Get to know your wiring). Partners can swap "how I work best" notes about plans, messages, touch and time alone. With children, behaviour often has a sensory or overload reason, so "What's too much right now?" is worth asking before "Why are you doing this?" A friend who cancels at the last minute may simply be out of energy, and offering an easier option,

like a walk or a message, keeps the door open. At work, written agendas, clear deadlines and quiet spaces help many people beyond the neurodivergent ones.

- **If you have ADHD and share a home.** Make the chore tools lighter. Log three days, not seven, with a tally on the fridge. Own a few jobs completely, each with a labelled alarm, instead of helping a bit with everything. Forgetting is a setup problem to fix together. More in the full chapter.

SCAN TO OPEN

ONLINE
Get to know your wiring
spreadloveandacceptance
.com/self-path

Common mix-ups

- **"Everyone's a bit autistic."** Everyone shares some traits, but autism is a whole pattern, present across life, and the phrase can make real needs sound small.
- **"ADHD just means you can't sit still."** Many people with ADHD, especially girls and women, are mostly inattentive or restless on the inside.
- **"They seem fine to me."** Masking can hide a lot, and seeming fine can cost someone the rest of their evening.
- **"Adjustments are special treatment."** They remove barriers so people can do what is expected, in the way glasses do.
- **"Autistic people lack empathy."** Many feel others' feelings strongly, and differences in how empathy is shown run both ways.

If you want to help someone else with this

- **Believe them** about what's hard, what hurts and what helps, even if it's different for you.
- **Be clear.** Say what you mean, give times, and write down anything important.
- **Ask what helps.** Every neurodivergent person is different, and their answer will be better than any list.
- **Protect their energy.** Quiet time, warnings before changes and a way out of loud places matter more than they look.
- **Enjoy their interests.** Listening to someone talk about what they love is one of the warmest things you can do.

WAYS TO SAY IT

"Is there anything about this place, or this plan, that would make it hard for you?" "You don't have to explain. Just tell me what you need."

When to get more help

If you wonder whether a difference is part of ongoing difficulties at school, work or home, for you or someone you care for, a doctor, school support staff or a psychologist can talk you through an assessment. Waiting lists can be long, so start early and write down what you notice.

Burnout, depression and anxiety are more common among neurodivergent people, often because of the stress of living in a world that doesn't fit. If you're exhausted most days, losing skills you used to have, or feeling hopeless, please talk to a doctor. **If you are having thoughts of hurting yourself,** please tell someone today.

In the US and Canada, call or text 988. In the UK and Ireland, call Samaritans free on 116 123. In Australia, call Lifeline on 13 11 14. In New Zealand, call or text 1737. Anywhere else, findahelpline.com lists free helplines.

A difference never excuses harm, and it never makes someone deserve harm. If someone uses your differences to control or belittle you, Not safe at home? has free, private help.

SCAN TO OPEN

ONLINE
Not safe at home?
spreadloveandacceptance
.com/safety

Tools and reading on the website

Tools helpers you use on the website

- Communication style quiz for a friendly look at how you send and receive words

SCAN TO OPEN

ONLINE
Communication style
quiz
spreadloveandacceptance
.com/communication-
style-quiz

THIS CONNECTS TO

Chapter 2 · Your wiring, weather and words page 25
Getting to know your own wiring

Book 3, Chapter 1 · Why we get out of tune Understanding Each Other, page 9
Pace, tone and meeting in the middle

Chapter 6 · Personality, temperament and change page 93
Dials, not boxes

Book 3, Chapter 2 · How communication works Understanding Each Other, page 27
Saying it so it lands for different minds

PUT IT TO USE

Communication style quiz
For a friendly look at how you send and receive words
spreadloveandacceptance.com/communication-style-quiz

The wiring card
A one-page "how I communicate" card to share
spreadloveandacceptance.com/wiring-card

Go deeper (free online) The full chapter, with the research, more examples and more to try: spreadloveandacceptance.com/book/understanding-9-minds-in-depth

Questions people ask

Some questions this book tends to raise, with short answers and where to read more.

Do I need to remember my childhood clearly for the first chapter to help?

Most people remember a handful of scenes and a general feeling, and that is plenty. The first chapter asks about the rules your home ran on, such as how feelings were handled or who did the worrying. Those rules tend to show up in how you react today more than in any one memory, so start with one rule you can name. Where your lens came from (Chapter 1, page 9) walks you through it.

What if looking back brings up something painful?

Stop there, and come back another day if you want to. Nobody has to finish a page. If old memories keep pulling you under, or you find yourself avoiding more and more of everyday life, talk to a doctor or counsellor. Worry, low mood and trauma (Book 2, Chapter 3, page 51) describes the kinds of help there are, and the help page at the front of this book (page 6) lists free places to start.

I think I might be autistic or have ADHD. Can this book tell me?

It can't, and nothing in it is a test. Minds that work differently (Chapter 7, page 111) describes how some minds work, so that you might recognise yourself or someone you love, and it says who can talk you through an assessment if you want one. Plenty of people find the descriptions useful whether or not they ever look for a diagnosis.

Can a grown-up really change their personality?

A little, slowly, and mostly by practising the thing you want to be more like. Personality, temperament and change (Chapter 6, page 93) treats traits as dials that move a few notches over the years. Every setting has its gifts and its costs, so the aim is a better fit with your life more than a new you.

My partner isn't interested in any of this. Is it still worth reading?

Yes. This book is about you, and it works if you are the only person in your home who ever opens it. Knowing your own wiring and weather makes it easier to say what you need, and the people around you often notice the change before they notice the book. If you later want to look at things together, Book 3 and Book 4 are written for that.

How do I know when a book isn't enough?

Most chapters have a short part called "When to get more help", with the signs to look out for. If you need someone now, the help page at the front of this book (page **6**) has numbers to call. Help beyond this book lists counsellors, helplines and support groups, and most of them are free.

SCAN TO OPEN

ONLINE
Help beyond this book
spreadloveandacceptance
.com/outside-help

Workpapers and tools in this book

Every workpaper and tool the chapters point to, in two separate lists, with the chapters that mention each one. All of them are free at spreadloveandacceptance.com, with no account, and what you type stays on your device.

Workpapers mentioned in this book

Pages to fill in, on your own or together.

WORKPAPER WP-02 **How much are you carrying?** · `spreadloveandacceptance.com/wp-02`

In: Your wiring, weather and words (page 25)

WORKPAPER WP-04 **What keeps coming back?** · `spreadloveandacceptance.com/wp-04`

In: Who you are becoming (page 45)

WORKPAPER WP-11 **The Calm-Down Kit** · `spreadloveandacceptance.com/wp-11`

In: Your wiring, weather and words (page 25), Who you are becoming (page 45), How feelings work (page 61)

Tools mentioned in this book

Interactive helpers to use on the site.

TOOL **Rewind the talk** · `spreadloveandacceptance.com/carrier-wave-decoder`

In: Self-worth, shame and self-compassion (page 79)

TOOL **Stay close: one small idea** · `spreadloveandacceptance.com/bonding`

In: How feelings work (page 61)

TOOL **How you connect: the 2-minute style quiz** · `spreadloveandacceptance.com/wavelength`

In: Where your lens came from (page 9), Personality, temperament and change (page 93)

TOOL **How you connect: how to talk to me** · `spreadloveandacceptance.com/wiring-card`

In: Personality, temperament and change (page 93), Minds that work differently (page 111)

TOOL **Old rules, new choices** · `spreadloveandacceptance.com/growing-up`

In: Where your lens came from (page 9)

TOOL **Cool-down corner: Upset right now?** · `spreadloveandacceptance.com/upset-right-now`

In: How feelings work (page 61), Self-worth, shame and self-compassion (page 79)

TOOL **My weather today** · `spreadloveandacceptance.com/quick-checks`

In: Your wiring, weather and words (page 25), How feelings work (page 61)

TOOL **Write it through** · `spreadloveandacceptance.com/write-it-through`

In: Self-worth, shame and self-compassion (page 79)

TOOL **Ask Professor Puddles** · `spreadloveandacceptance.com/ask`

In: Self-worth, shame and self-compassion (page 79)

TOOL **Read your way** · `spreadloveandacceptance.com/how-you-take-things-in`

In: Minds that work differently (page 111)

TOOL **Gentle games: the Re-check Drive (calm football)** · `spreadloveandacceptance.com/recheck-drive`

In: Who you are becoming (page 45)

Words used in this book

The book's own words, each in one plain sentence. All of them are at spreadloveandacceptance.com/glossary.

Alexithymia
Finding it hard to notice, name or describe your own feelings. It is a trait on a scale, not an illness, and it is more common in some autistic people. Naming body signals first can help.

Battery
Your battery is how much energy you have left today. Full means you have room to spare; low means you're running on empty. "How much are you carrying?" measures the other side of it, your load: a higher load score means a heavier load, and a lower battery.

A bid
A bid is any small reach for attention or connection, like "look at this," a sigh or a joke.

Calm-Down Kit
The Calm-Down Kit is your own short list of what settles your body, chosen ahead of time so you don't have to think when you're wound up.

Carrier wave
The carrier wave is the feeling that travels underneath the words: the tone that arrives before the meaning does.

Check-in
A check-in is a short, planned talk that keeps small things small. The daily one takes about ninety seconds, with no debating.

Double empathy
The idea, from the autistic researcher Damian Milton, that misunderstandings between autistic and non-autistic people run both ways: each finds the other hard to read, so neither side is simply "missing" something.

Frequency
Your frequency is your natural pace: how fast you decide, talk, reply and recover.

If-then plan
A small plan written as "If this happens, then I will do that", which makes a new habit easier to start (Peter Gollwitzer).

The ladder
Three everyday states: calm and connected, revved up, running on empty. My weather today calls them clear, gusty and fogged in. A best guess about your state, not a measurement.

The load
The load is all the work of a shared life, including the thinking, planning and remembering that nobody sees.

Masking
Masking is hiding the way you're wired to fit in, which can be very tiring over time.

Monotropism

A theory of autistic attention: attention gathers deeply on a few things at a time, rather than spreading thinly across many. Switching away can take real effort.

My weather today

My weather today is a one-minute check on your own conditions today, like sleep, stress and energy: Clear means calm and connected, Gusty means revved up, and Fogged in means running on empty.

Owner (one owner per job)

The owner of a job is the one person who makes sure it gets done from start to finish, so nobody has to keep asking.

Pressure

Pressure, in My weather today, is how much you were already carrying today: light, building or heavy. Behind the forecast sits a rough tally from 0 to 100; under 45 leaves room in the day, 65 or more means go gently. It is a reading of what you told it, not a score or a grade.

Repair

A repair is anything that stops a tense moment from getting worse, like a joke, a softer tone or "Can we start over?"

The rulebook from home

The rulebook from home is the unwritten set of rules you grew up with, about love, upset, chores and rest, that you may still expect others to follow.

Second arrow

The extra pain we add on top of a hard moment, such as being angry at ourselves for being sad. The first arrow is the event; the second is what we tell ourselves about it (a Buddhist image).

Static

Static is the crackle between two people when the words are fine but the tone, pace or timing doesn't match.

Stress tank

How much stress you are already carrying, from How much are you carrying?, scored from 0 (empty) to 1 (full). Under 0.30 is low, 0.30 to 0.59 moderate, 0.60 and up high. A fuller tank means less room to take more on. (Your battery is the other side of it: energy left.)

Talk window

The talk window says whether now is a good time for a big conversation: open, wait a little, or closed for today.

Wave Code

Four letters from the style quiz in How you connect, one for each of four preferences about how you take in and send words. Each letter shows where you lean on a dial today: a shorthand for preferences, not a personality type.

Wired differently

Being wired differently means your brain works in a less common way, such as being autistic, ADHD, dyslexic or highly sensitive, which changes how words land.

Wiring

Your wiring is the way your brain and senses take in words, sound, change and people. It stays the same from day to day.

Workpaper

A page you fill in, on your own or with someone, about your own week or your own side. Every workpaper is free to print or to fill in on the website.

Your lens

Your lens is the set of understandings about yourself, other people and what they owe you that you picked up growing up and still use without noticing.

Research notes

The 105 studies and books these chapters mention, in short. Each one was looked up and checked. The full list, with what each study found, how strong the finding is and where to read it, is free online:
`spreadloveandacceptance.com/research`.

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